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BSc Business Information systems

(Ethical Concerns on Employee Privacy in Remote Work Monitoring Systems and Its impact on Employee Productivity among Remote Workers in Sri Lankan context.)

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By

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DECLARATION

This work is being submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of BSc (Hons) Business Information Systems and has not previously been accepted in substance for any degree and is not being concurrently submitted in candidature for any degree.

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Abstract

This research examines ethical concerns about employee privacy in remote work monitoring systems and how these concerns relate to employee productivity among remote workers in Sri Lanka. As organizations increasingly embed tools such as screen/activity tracking, time logging, webcam checks, and keystroke monitoring into Business Information Systems (BIS), employees may experience blurred work-home boundaries, perceived intrusions, stress, and reduced autonomy. Guided by Social Exchange Theory, the research adopts an interpretivist, exploratory-descriptive design using a structured online questionnaire distributed through convenience sampling. Responses from 60-70 Sri Lankan remote workers were analyzed in R using descriptive frequencies, percentages, and visualizations. Findings indicate that monitoring is widespread (about three quarters report being monitored) and often frequent, with screen/activity monitoring and time tracking most common. Privacy concern is high (around three quarters agree monitoring raises privacy issues), while trust in ethical data use is moderate and conditional, with many neutral responses. Perceived productivity benefits are mixed and centered near neutrality, whereas stress perceptions lean neutral-to-agree. Overall, remote monitoring is not strongly viewed as improving performance. The study concludes that ethically designed BIS emphasizing transparency, informed consent, proportionality, data minimization, and outcome-based evaluation are essential to sustain trust and productivity in Sri Lanka's evolving remote work context.

Ethical Concerns on Employee Privacy in Remote Work Monitoring Systems and Its impact on Employee Productivity among Remote Workers in Sri Lankan context.

Chapter 1.

Introduction

The rapid expansion of remote work after the COVID-19 pandemic has reshaped how organizations manage employees, coordinate tasks, and ensure accountability across dispersed teams. In response, many firms have strengthened their Business Information Systems (BIS) by integrating employee monitoring features such as time tracking, screen and activity logging, screenshot capture, webcam checks, and, in some cases, keystroke analytics. While these tools can support supervision, performance management, and data security, they also introduce significant ethical concerns particularly around employee privacy because remote work often takes place within personal home environments and may involve personal devices. When monitoring is frequent, intrusive, or poorly communicated, it can blur the boundaries between work and private life, weaken employee autonomy, and signal mistrust, which may increase stress and negatively influence motivation, job satisfaction, and productivity.

In the Sri Lankan context, these tensions are intensified by differences in organizational culture, uneven awareness of digital rights, and inconsistent monitoring policies and governance practices. Therefore, the central issue is not whether monitoring should exist, but how BIS-based monitoring can be designed and implemented ethically to balance legitimate organizational oversight with employee dignity, privacy, and sustainable performance. Accordingly, this chapter establishes the foundation for the study by presenting the background of the study and clearly defining the research problem. It then outlines the research questions and objectives, followed by the scope and limitations of the study and its significance for academic knowledge, organizational practice, and policy development in Sri Lanka.

Background of the Study

The global shift to remote work was greatly accelerated by the COVID-19 pandemic, changing how organizations manage employees and daily operations. In this new work model, Business Information Systems (BIS) play a central role by enabling collaboration, supporting workflow coordination, maintaining accountability, and protecting organizational data across dispersed teams. To manage performance at a distance, many organizations have integrated monitoring tools into BIS, such as time-tracking software, screen/activity monitoring, webcam surveillance, screenshot capture, and keystroke logging. These technologies provide managers with data that can support performance evaluation, resource allocation, and productivity management. (Battisti, et al., 2022)

However, the increasing use of monitoring systems has also raised serious ethical concerns about employee privacy, especially because remote work takes place inside employees' homes and sometimes on personal devices. Employees may experience continuous monitoring as intrusive, leading to stress, lower job satisfaction, and reduced trust in management. When monitoring extends beyond work-related tasks, it can blur personal and professional boundaries and create stronger concerns about privacy rights and personal dignity. (The rise of workplace surveillance and its impact on productivity, n.d.)

In Sri Lanka, these concerns are further shaped by local organizational culture, communication practices, and varying levels of awareness about digital rights. Some employers implement monitoring with minimal consultation or clear explanation, while others emphasize transparency and informed consent. This inconsistency can create ethical and even legal challenges for organizations and employees. Therefore, the key issue is not whether monitoring is required, but how BIS-based monitoring can be designed and implemented ethically, balancing organizational productivity needs with employee privacy, autonomy, and trust.

Research Problem

As remote work expands particularly after the COVID-19 pandemic employee monitoring has become a common feature of Business Information Systems (BIS). These systems support decision-making, accountability, and performance tracking, but they also introduce ethical concerns related to privacy, fairness, and trust. Many employees perceive monitoring tools such as activity trackers, webcam checks, random screenshots, and keystroke logging as stressful and invasive. Over time, constant observation may reduce morale, weaken loyalty, and harm motivation, which can ultimately reduce productivity the very outcome these monitoring systems are intended to improve. (How Employee Tracking Hurts Morale and Productivity, 2025)

A key challenge is the lack of clear ethical guidelines and consistent organizational frameworks for responsible monitoring. In many cases, organizations prioritize operational efficiency and data-driven control while giving less attention to employee dignity, consent, transparency, and data security. Without ethical standards, monitoring can lead to misuse of employee data, privacy violations, and possible legal consequences under data protection principles. (Negative Effects of Employee Monitoring & Smart Ways to Avoid Them, n.d.)

These concerns become more complex in Sri Lanka due to differences in organizational culture, uneven awareness of employee digital rights, and weak enforcement of workplace privacy policies. As more Sri Lankan organizations adopt monitoring technologies, they face the challenge of maintaining productivity without damaging trust or violating privacy. Poorly implemented monitoring can lead to negative outcomes such as job dissatisfaction, stress, high turnover, and reputational harm. (Employee Surveillance Can Harm Wellbeing and Productivity at Work, 2014)

Therefore, the research problem of this study is: how Business Information Systems can be ethically designed and implemented to protect employee privacy while maintaining productivity in remote work settings in Sri Lanka. This study investigates ethical privacy concerns related to monitoring and examines their perceived impact on remote workers' trust, motivation, stress, and productivity, with the aim of supporting fair, transparent, and trustworthy monitoring practices.

Research Questions

1. What is Sri Lankan remote workers' primary ethical concerns regarding employee privacy in remote work monitoring systems?
2. In Sri Lanka, what effects does remote monitoring have on worker trust, motivation, and productivity?
3. How do employers and employees in Sri Lanka feel about the use of monitoring tools in remote work settings?
4. Which organizational and ethical frameworks can direct the responsible deployment of monitoring systems in remote work environments?
5. How can BIS be developed to maintain organizational trust and productivity while guaranteeing moral employee monitoring?

Research Objectives

- To investigate Sri Lankan remote workers' ethical concerns about employee privacy in monitoring systems.
- To evaluate how employee monitoring procedures affect workers' trust, motivation, and productivity in remote work settings.
- To examine how employers and employees in Sri Lankan organizations view remote work monitoring tools.
- To determine the best practices and ethical frameworks that promote privacy protection and boost efficiency
- To make suggestions for BIS design that maintain productivity and trust while guaranteeing ethical monitoring.

Scope and Limitation

The ethical issues surrounding employee privacy in remote work monitoring systems are the main focus of this study, which also looks at how these issues affect remote workers' productivity in Sri Lanka. It specifically looks at how Business Information Systems (BIS) can be used in an ethical way to strike a balance between employee privacy and the accountability and productivity objectives of the organization. The study will assess the ethical implications of common monitoring tools on privacy, autonomy, and trust. These tools include webcam surveillance systems, activity tracking platforms, keystroke loggers, and time-tracking applications.

Organizational and employee viewpoints will be taken into account. While organizations prioritize efficiency, accountability, and performance management, employees place a higher value on privacy, fairness, and personal freedom. The study aims to understand how monitoring can be applied fairly and responsibly in the local remote work environment by incorporating ethical theories, organizational best practices, and pertinent Sri Lankan labor and data protection regulations. This will ensure an ethical balance.

Instead of concentrating on a single industry, the study's scope encompasses remote work practices across several Sri Lankan sectors. Because of its wider scope, the research findings can be applied to a variety of organizations that use remote or hybrid work models. The study will have a solid theoretical basis since it will mostly rely on secondary data from sources like policy reports, case studies, and scholarly journals. The study uses established evidence and cross-referenced academic sources to ensure credibility and reliability, even though primary data collection may be limited.

International literature and case comparisons will be used to identify global best practices and ethical standards, even though the research focusses on the Sri Lankan context. However, the findings' full generalizability may be constrained by differences in organizational structures, legal frameworks, and cultural norms. Notwithstanding these drawbacks, the study is still useful, relevant, and flexible, providing practical advice for Sri Lankan organizations looking to create morally sound and efficient BIS-based remote monitoring systems.

Significance of the Study

This Research is important because it examines how employee productivity is impacted by remote work monitoring systems in Sri Lankan organizations and addresses the growing ethical concerns regarding employee privacy in these systems. Understanding how to strike a balance between productivity and privacy has become crucial for managers, legislators, and workers alike as remote work becomes an inevitable part of modern employment. The research's conclusions will have scholarly, professional, policy, and societal significance.

Academic Significance

Academically, this study adds to the expanding corpus of knowledge in the domains of human resource management, workplace ethics, and business information systems. It offers a more thorough comprehension of how moral dilemmas in digital surveillance affect worker trust and productivity. It addresses a research gap in regional studies of remote work ethics by concentrating on the Sri Lankan context and provides a framework that incorporates management, legal, and technological insights. Students, academics, and researchers interested in the relationship between productivity, technology, and ethics in remote work environments will find value in the findings.

Practical Significance for Organizations

This study provides organizations with useful advice on how to create and execute moral monitoring procedures using business information systems. It assists decision-makers in coming up with ways to increase output while preserving the dignity and privacy of workers. In order to prevent negative outcomes like low morale, stress, or diminished loyalty, the research will offer frameworks and best practices for creating transparent, equitable, and trust-based monitoring systems. For Sri Lankan employers looking to boost productivity without sacrificing moral and legal principles, this advice is especially pertinent.

Policy and Legal Relevance

The study is also important for Sri Lankan regulators and policymakers. The research can guide the creation of more comprehensive policies by examining the relationship between organizational monitoring practices and current labor and data protection laws. These results can be used to help develop moral and legal standards that guarantee accountability, equity, and respect for workers' rights in digital workplaces.

Societal and Ethical Importance

This study raises awareness of employee rights, digital ethics, and responsible workplace technology use on a larger social level. It emphasizes how crucial it is to uphold human autonomy, dignity, and trust in a time of growing digital surveillance. The study helps to create a more moral, sustainable, and human-centered approach to remote work by addressing these issues in the Sri Lankan context.

To sum up, this research is important because it promotes socially conscious technology use, supports moral business conduct, informs the creation of national policies, and advances scholarly knowledge. In the end, it seeks to advance a sustainable and well-balanced remote work environment where productivity and employee privacy coexist peacefully.

Outline of the dissertation

This dissertation is organized into six chapters that systematically explain the study from its background and problem identification to findings, discussion, and recommendations. The structure begins by introducing the research context of remote work monitoring and ethical privacy concerns in Sri Lanka, then reviews existing literature and frameworks that support the study. It next explains the research methodology used to collect and interpret data from Sri Lankan remote workers. After that, the dissertation presents the findings and analysis, followed by a discussion that links the results to theory, ethical governance, and legal principles. Finally, it provides practical recommendations for organizations, BIS designers, and policymakers, along with directions for future research. The chapter structure is summarized below.

Chapter-by-chapter structure

- Chapter 1: Introduction

This chapter introduces the research topic and explains the background of the study, highlighting the growth of remote work and the increased use of monitoring tools within Business Information Systems (BIS). It presents the research problem and explains why ethical privacy concerns matter in Sri Lanka. The chapter then outlines the research questions and objectives, followed by the scope and limitations of the study. It concludes by explaining the significance of the research for academics, organizations, policymakers, and society.

- Chapter 2: Literature Review

This chapter critically reviews previous studies related to BIS-based monitoring in remote work, including the technologies used and their intended benefits such as accountability, productivity, and security. It examines ethical concerns such as privacy invasion, reduced autonomy, trust issues, psychological stress, and data misuse. It also reviews legal and ethical compliance principles (including PDPA and international standards) and presents best practices and governance frameworks. The chapter ends by identifying research gaps and justifying the need for this study in the Sri Lankan context.

- Chapter 3: Research Methodology

This chapter describes the philosophical foundation (interpretivism) and theoretical framework (Social Exchange Theory) used in the study. It explains the research design as exploratory and descriptive, supported by qualitative interpretation with descriptive statistical summaries. The chapter details the sampling approach, participant profile, and the data collection process using a Google Forms questionnaire. It also explains how data was analyzed using frequencies, percentages, bar charts, and box plots in R Studio, and outlines the ethical considerations followed during the research.

- Chapter 4: Data Presentation, Findings and Analysis

This chapter presents the study findings based on survey responses from Sri Lankan remote workers. It provides demographic summaries and explains monitoring practices such as tool types and monitoring frequency. It then reports findings on privacy concerns, trust in ethical data use, perceived productivity effects, stress impact, and overall work performance. The results are presented using descriptive statistics and visual formats (tables, pie charts, bar graphs, and box plots), followed by clear interpretation of key trends and patterns.

- Chapter 5: Discussion of Findings and Overall Conclusion

This chapter discusses the results presented in Chapter 4 by linking them to the literature review, ethical principles, governance frameworks, and relevant legal standards. It interprets how monitoring practices influence privacy, trust, stress, and productivity within Sri Lanka's remote work environment. The findings are also explained using Social Exchange Theory to show how monitoring affects perceived fairness and trust relationships. The chapter concludes by summarizing the overall conclusions of the study and highlighting the main contributions.

- Chapter 6: Future Recommendations

This chapter provides recommendations based on the findings and discussion. It offers practical guidance for Sri Lankan organizations on ethical monitoring policies, transparency, consent, data minimization, retention limits, and employee participation. It recommends shifting from activity-based monitoring toward outcome-based performance evaluation and strengthening BIS governance through audits and ethics committees. The chapter also proposes national-level policy suggestions and presents recommendations for future research, including longitudinal studies, industry comparisons, and deeper qualitative investigations.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

1. Introduction

Remote work has grown significantly in recent years, especially after the COVID-19 pandemic, forcing organizations to implement a number of monitoring systems to guarantee data security, performance, and accountability. In order to gather and handle employee data, these tools which include digital analytics, time-tracking apps, webcam surveillance, and keystroke logging are being incorporated more and more into business information systems (BIS). But because these technologies frequently make it difficult to distinguish between personal space and professional supervision, they raise serious questions about privacy, autonomy, trust, and ethics.

This review examines earlier studies on remote monitoring systems, emphasizing organizational results, employee perceptions, and ethical and legal concerns. Additionally, it highlights research gaps pertinent to the Sri Lankan context of remote work and identifies frameworks and best practices that have been proposed to strike a balance between privacy protection and monitoring needs.

(Grisold, et al., 2024)

2. Business Information Systems and Remote Monitoring

Definition and Technological Components of BIS in Monitoring

Business Information Systems (BIS) are socio-technical structures that support organizational goals by integrating people, technology, and processes. BIS combines monitoring tools like activity logs, productivity dashboards, time-tracking software, and security systems with platforms for communication and collaboration in remote work settings. Research indicates that numerous organizations hurriedly adopted such systems during and after the COVID-19 pandemic without thoroughly weighing their ethical ramifications. Remote work creates additional risks to employee

privacy and data security because BIS frequently gathers data from personal devices and home networks. (C. Nurse, et al., 2021)

Benefits: Productivity, Accountability, and Security

Employers defend employee monitoring as a way to increase data security, productivity, and accountability. BIS tools allow managers to assess time usage, ensure compliance with company policies, and detect security anomalies that could indicate data breaches or misuse. Remote monitoring has been shown in some studies to result in modest increases in productivity. However, critics argue that quantitative data (like keystrokes or hours logged) fails to capture qualitative aspects of work, such as creativity, problem-solving, and teamwork. When data-driven metrics are overused, they may encourage compliance at the expense of true productivity.

Such systems may improve accountability in Sri Lanka, where remote work is still adjusting to digital transformation, but they may also make employees more uneasy if ethical safeguards are inadequate or nonexistent. (Benefits of Continuous Monitoring in Organizations, n.d.)

3. Ethical Concerns Associated with Monitoring

Privacy and Invasion of Personal Space

One of the most commonly mentioned ethical issues with remote monitoring is privacy invasion. Monitoring systems may unintentionally use webcams to capture private or family settings or gather information after hours. According to research, these kinds of practices cause stress and discomfort in workers by making them feel like they are being watched all the time. Keystroke logging, audio recording, and random screenshots are of particular concern to many employees, especially when they are unsure of how or when data is used. (The Eavesdropping Employer: A Twenty-First Century Framework for Employee Monitoring, 2010)

This blurring of boundaries can be particularly problematic in Sri Lanka, where a large number of remote workers operate from shared or family spaces, increasing emotional strain and privacy concerns.

Trust, Autonomy, and Psychological Well-Being

Overzealous monitoring damages the relationship of trust between employers and workers. According to studies, morale and creativity suffer when workers feel mistrusted. When every action is tracked, autonomy, a major factor in job satisfaction, is diminished. Over-monitoring can also lead to psychological effects such as stress, burnout, and constant vigilance, negatively affecting productivity and well-being. (Glavin, et al., 2024)

Perceived mistrust through monitoring can exacerbate disengagement in Sri Lankan culture, which values interpersonal respect and individual dignity in the workplace.

Data Misuse, Bias, and Discrimination

Concerns regarding bias, discrimination, and misuse are raised by extensive data collection. In the absence of stringent governance, data may be misconstrued, resulting in unfair performance reviews. Employees who take regular breaks or complete creative, non-measurable tasks, for instance, may be penalized by algorithms. Research cautions that some groups, such as women and minorities, may be disproportionately impacted by these biases. (Employee Surveillance Is a Working Mom's Nightmare, n.d.)

Transparency, Consent, and Legal/Ethical Compliance

Transparency is necessary for ethical monitoring; staff members need to be aware of what, how, and why they are being watched. Consent, data minimization, and limited retention are key components of legal frameworks like the GDPR, CCPA, and Sri Lanka's newly enacted Personal Data Protection Act (PDPA). Employees may feel misled or helpless as a result of many organizations' continued lack of clear policies or poor communication of them. (Stechynskyi, 2024)

4. Employee Perspectives and Experience

Employee Perceptions of Privacy and Fairness

Research continuously demonstrates that remote workers are suspicious of monitoring, especially when it involves webcam surveillance and sporadic screenshots that invade their privacy. When

data is applied inconsistently or punitively across teams, employees also start to doubt fairness. This feeling of injustice erodes drive and breeds animosity.

Impact on Morale, Loyalty, and Motivation

Employee engagement, morale, and organizational loyalty are all negatively impacted when workers believe that monitoring is excessive. On the other hand, acceptance levels increase when monitoring is open, motivated, and connected to employee benefits. If employees know that data promotes performance improvement rather than punishment, they are more likely to cooperate. (Lingwal, 2025)

Culture, Context, and Individual Differences

Culture, industry, and individual background all influence how monitoring is accepted. Employees may initially put up with some monitoring in collectivist cultures like Sri Lanka in order to maintain discipline and teamwork, but ongoing surveillance that violates privacy can still cause discontent. Employee responses are also influenced by personal factors like job role, home environment, and prior surveillance experiences.

5. Organizational Motivations, Justifications, and Risks

Motivations: Productivity, Security, Compliance

Organizations use BIS-based monitoring to prevent fraud, ensure compliance, protect sensitive data, and effectively manage distributed teams, according to Canonigo (2024) and Remote Working Pre- and Post-COVID-19 (2021). These tools support managerial decision-making and resource allocation. (Canonigo, n.d.)

Risks: Productivity Backfire, Legal & Reputational Risk

Over-monitoring, despite its goal of increasing productivity, can actually have the opposite effect, lowering employee engagement and creativity. Even in the absence of close supervision, research indicates that trust-based remote work frequently boosts productivity. Overzealous monitoring can also put businesses at risk for ethical transgressions, unfair labor practices, and privacy law

violations, among other legal and reputational issues. (Does Employee Monitoring Increase Productivity? Expectation vs. Reality, n.d.)

Such errors could harm an organization's reputation and employee retention in Sri Lanka, particularly in sectors that depend on highly qualified workers.

6. Best Practices and Ethical Frameworks

Transparency, Consent, and Communication

Open communication is crucial, according to academics. Workers should be aware of what is being watched, how information is used, and who has access to it. Ethical compliance is encouraged by explicit written policies, consent procedures, and frequent updates. (Gaffin, 2025)

Minimization, Purpose Limitation, and Data Governance

Using BIS ethically necessitates ensuring strong data governance and only gathering the data that is required. Retention periods should be specified, anonymization should be used, and access should be limited. Data should only be used for the specified purpose, such as increasing security or productivity, and not for irrelevant personal or disciplinary assessments.

Outcome-oriented vs Time or Activity Metrics

Experts advise moving away from activity-based metrics (such as keystrokes or hours worked) and towards outcome-oriented metrics that emphasize innovation, quality, and deliverables. This method feels less intrusive while promoting independence and creativity. (Ethical Strategies for Monitoring Remote Teams: 5 Expert Tips, n.d.)

Employee Participation, Feedback, and Continuous Improvement

Employee acceptance is increased when they are involved in creating monitoring policies. More sustainable practices result from routinely collecting feedback, assessing psychological effects, and modifying systems as necessary. (Niekerk, 2022)

Legal and Ethical Compliance

Organizations must respect the ethical standards established by professional associations and adhere to national and international privacy regulations. Establishing ethics committees, accountability frameworks, and recurring audits fosters trust and helps stop abuse. (Grisold, et al., 2024)

7. Role of BIS as a Balancing Tool

When properly designed, BIS can strike a balance between privacy and productivity, so they are not necessarily surveillance tools. Important BIS design guidelines consist of,

Table 1/Literature Review/Role of Bis as a Balancing Tool

Data transparency modules	Dashboards that tell staff members what information is gathered and why.
Privacy-by-design	Incorporating privacy safeguards (such as anonymization and restricted data access) into BIS from the outset.
Role-based access control	Ensuring that sensitive monitoring data is only accessed by authorized personnel.
User Feedback Mechanisms	Letting staff members offer suggestions for appropriate monitoring procedures.
Ethical algorithms	Ensuring the impartiality, explain ability, and equity of AI-driven evaluations.

BIS can serve as ethical mediators, encouraging accountability and transparency while protecting privacy, according to recent studies like Digital Surveillance in organizations. As remote work continues to grow, these design strategies may help Sri Lanka implement equitable monitoring regulations. (Grisold, et al., 2024)

8. Research Gaps

A review of the literature reveals a number of gaps,

- A dearth of empirical studies examining the true effects of BIS design elements (such as consent systems and transparency modules) on worker well-being and productivity.
- There is little attention paid to developing nations like Sri Lanka, whose organizational cultures, legal systems, and level of digital readiness diverge from those in the West.
- There aren't many long-term studies looking at how remote monitoring affects productivity and psychology over time.
- Employee perspectives are not sufficiently included in research that is dominated by organizational or technological perspectives.
- Stronger integration of ethical theory with BIS design is required in order to directly connect moral principles to the creation of systems and the formulation of policies.

9. Conclusion

The literature review indicates a persistent conflict between the ethical duties to protect privacy, trust, and equity and the organizational demands for accountability, security, and productivity. A key component of this equilibrium is business information systems. They can improve employee satisfaction and performance if they are created ethically.

As remote work grows in popularity in Sri Lanka, organizations need to modify international ethical frameworks to accommodate local legal and cultural norms. Making deliberate decisions about what information to gather, how to use it, and how to preserve transparency are all necessary for ethical monitoring. The literature review emphasizes that trust, consent, and ethical design values that serve as the cornerstone of this study are more important for sustainable productivity than continuous monitoring.

Chapter 3.

Research Methodology

Introduction

The approach taken to investigate ethical concerns about employee privacy in remote work monitoring systems and their effect on perceived productivity in the Sri Lankan context is described in this chapter.

The study concentrates on remote workers who are tracked by Business Information Systems (BIS) using digital tools. It seeks to comprehend how privacy, trust, stress, and productivity are perceived in relation to monitoring practices.

The research context, philosophical underpinnings, methodological approach, sampling strategy, data collection and analysis procedures and ethical considerations are all presented in this chapter.

Research Context, Methodology and Theory

- Research Context

Remote work has become increasingly common in Sri Lanka, particularly in sectors such as information technology, digital freelancing, education, customer service, and business administration. As organizations continue to adopt remote working arrangements, they are also making greater use of monitoring tools such as time-tracking systems, activity monitoring software, and performance dashboards. Although these tools may improve accountability, coordination, and productivity, they also raise important ethical concerns relating to employee privacy, trust, and autonomy. In the Sri Lankan context, where remote work practices and digital monitoring are still evolving, it is important to understand how employees perceive these systems and their impact on work-related outcomes. Therefore, this study examines ethical concerns regarding employee privacy in remote work monitoring systems from the perspective of remote workers in Sri Lanka.

- Methodology

This study adopts a survey-based research approach to examine the perceptions of remote workers regarding monitoring practices, privacy concerns, trust, stress, and perceived productivity. The methodology is designed to gather structured responses from remote employees in Sri Lanka and to interpret the findings in a clear and systematic manner. By focusing on employee perceptions and experiences, the study aims to provide meaningful insights into the ethical implications of monitoring systems used in remote work environments.

- Theory

This research is supported by Social Exchange Theory, which explains workplace relationships in terms of fairness, reciprocity, and mutual trust between employers and employees. According to this theory, when employees perceive organizational practices as fair and respectful, they are more likely to respond positively through trust, commitment, and improved performance. However, when monitoring becomes excessive or intrusive, employees may interpret it as a sign of mistrust, which can negatively affect their sense of privacy, increase stress, and reduce job satisfaction and productivity. Therefore, Social Exchange Theory provides a useful framework for understanding how remote work monitoring practices may influence employee perceptions and productivity outcomes.

Philosophical Base

Interpretivism serves as the foundation for this study.

Understanding human experiences, perceptions, and social realities is the main goal of interpretivism. An interpretivist philosophy is appropriate for this research since it looks at how remote workers view monitoring practices and explain their effects on productivity and privacy.

The study's goal is to interpret meanings and experiences related to employee monitoring systems rather than test cause-and-effect relationships.

Research Methodology and Strategy of Inquiry

Descriptive statistical summaries are used to support the qualitative research methodology used in this study. An exploratory and descriptive research design is employed,

- ❖ Ethical concerns regarding remote monitoring in Sri Lanka are still developing, so the exploratory design is appropriate.
- ❖ Worker perceptions and monitoring procedures can be presented methodically thanks to the descriptive design.

A structured survey disseminated via Google Forms is used as part of the survey-based qualitative inquiry research strategy.

Sampling Strategy

This research used a convenience sampling technique. Remote workers in Sri Lanka were given access to the survey via professional networking sites, WhatsApp, and email. Since remote workers are geographically scattered and mainly accessible via digital communication channels, this approach was chosen because of the respondents' accessibility. Furthermore, probability sampling was not possible for the scope of this academic study due to time and resource constraints. Convenience sampling is thought to be appropriate for qualitative exploratory studies that seek to understand perceptions and experiences rather than generate statistically generalizable results, even though it may limit the findings' generalizability to the entire population of Sri Lankan remote workers.

Details of Participants

The last sample was composed of 60 – 70 remote employees based in Sri Lanka. Respondents had a wide spectrum of professional areas and included Information Technology, Education and Online Teaching, Customer Support, Business and Administration, and Freelancing and Digital Services. Geographical diversity amongst the remote workforce resulted in the selection of respondents who represented various provinces in the country. Besides, respondents had different degrees of

experience with remote work, with less than one year and over four years. The informed consent of all the participants was voluntary and guaranteed ethical association in the study.

Data Collection Process

- Primary Data Collection

As a source of primary data, a structured questionnaire was designed and administered by means of Google Forms. All the questions in the questionnaire were closed-ended to make the questionnaire easy to understand, maximize response rates and facilitate the organized comparison of the answers. The survey touched on some of the main areas that are of interest to the research objectives such as monitoring practice; type and frequency of monitoring, employee attitude and perception of privacy and trust, perceived consequences of monitoring on productivity and stress and simple demographic characteristics of the work such as the job field and province of work. An informed consent question was mandatory under the beginning of the survey in the Google Form. Participants who chose Yes only could go to the other questions hence ethical principles of voluntary participation were met.

- Secondary Data Collection

Secondary data was employed in order to improve the theoretical and conceptual base of the study. Related literature was examined based on peer-reviewed journal articles of workplace surveillance, employee monitoring, ethics, and Business Information Systems. Other sources were industry reports on remote monitoring tools, case studies of monitoring practices used by an organization, and legal provisions on data protection and privacy, including the Personal Data Protection Act (PDPA) of Sri Lanka and the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). Comparison between international findings and the context of Sri Lanka was made possible through the analysis of secondary sources, which allowed to expand the credibility of the study as well as the depth of it.

Data Analysis Process

The research has a qualitative approach and therefore the analysis of the data is conducted on the descriptive interpretation as opposed to the statistical hypothesis testing.

The responses collected in the form of Google Forms were exported as a CSV file and processed using R Studio. This study is qualitative in its overall purpose and interpretation, while structured survey responses and descriptive statistical summaries were used only to support the analysis and presentation of respondents' perceptions.

The analysis methods used include,

- ❖ Frequency distributions (to indicate the number of respondents who picked each option)
- ❖ Percentage analysis (to comprehend the percentage of responses)
- ❖ Basic comparisons of groups (e.g., frequency of monitoring, perceived stress).
- ❖ Bar charts and tables: visual interpretation.

There are no sophisticated statistical tests, regression analysis, and inferential procedures employed in this study because the main purpose of the study is to investigate and analyze the employees' perceptions instead of proving that there is a cause-and-effect relationship.

The findings are also presented in tables and visual charts and the results are interpreted qualitatively by establishing the general trends and patterns with regards to,

- ❖ Privacy concerns
- ❖ Trust in organizations
- ❖ Monitoring practices
- ❖ Perceived productivity
- ❖ Work-related stress

In this way, clarity, simplicity, and adherence to the qualitative nature of the research are ensured.

Ethical Considerations

High ethical standards were maintained throughout the research.

- ❖ The involvement was voluntary.
- ❖ Prior to the completion of the surveys, informed consent was provided.
- ❖ No personal identification data were gathered.
- ❖ The purpose of the data was purely academic.
- ❖ All the citation of all the secondary sources is done in Harvard style.
- ❖ Results are given without any manipulation.

Ethical adherence is particularly important because the research itself concerns problems of privacy and ethical monitoring.

Conclusion

The research paper is qualitative, exploratory yet descriptive as it seeks to explore ethical issues associated with employee monitoring systems and their sensed effects on productivity in Sri Lanka. The research will present valuable information to the research question by integrating both survey results and other secondary literature that will bring important insights into privacy, trust, and ethical monitoring in Business Information Systems. The chosen methodology enables unbiased explanation of the employee perceptions and ensures academic rigor and ethical responsibility.

Chapter 4.

Data Presentation, Findings and Analysis

Introduction

The chapter provides the results of the research using information gathered among 68 remote workers in Sri Lanka. The answers collected using the questionnaire, Google Form were processed using the R Studio. The results were presented clearly using descriptive methods of frequencies, percentages, pie charts, bar graphs, and box plots. This chapter aims at presenting and inference of the results associated with employee monitoring practices, privacy issues, trust in organization, perceived productivity, and work-related stress among remote employees.

Demographic Profile of Respondents

Job Field Distribution

```
> job_freq
      Business / Administration      Customer Support / BPO      Education / online Teaching      Freelancing / Digital Services
      Information Technology (IT / Software)      other
      11      2      9      8
      28      10
```

Figure 1/Job frequency

```
> job_percent
      Business / Administration      Customer Support / BPO      Education / online Teaching      Freelancing / Digital Services
      16.176471      2.941176      13.235294      11.764706
      Information Technology (IT / Software)      other
      41.176471      14.705882
```

Figure 2/Job percentage

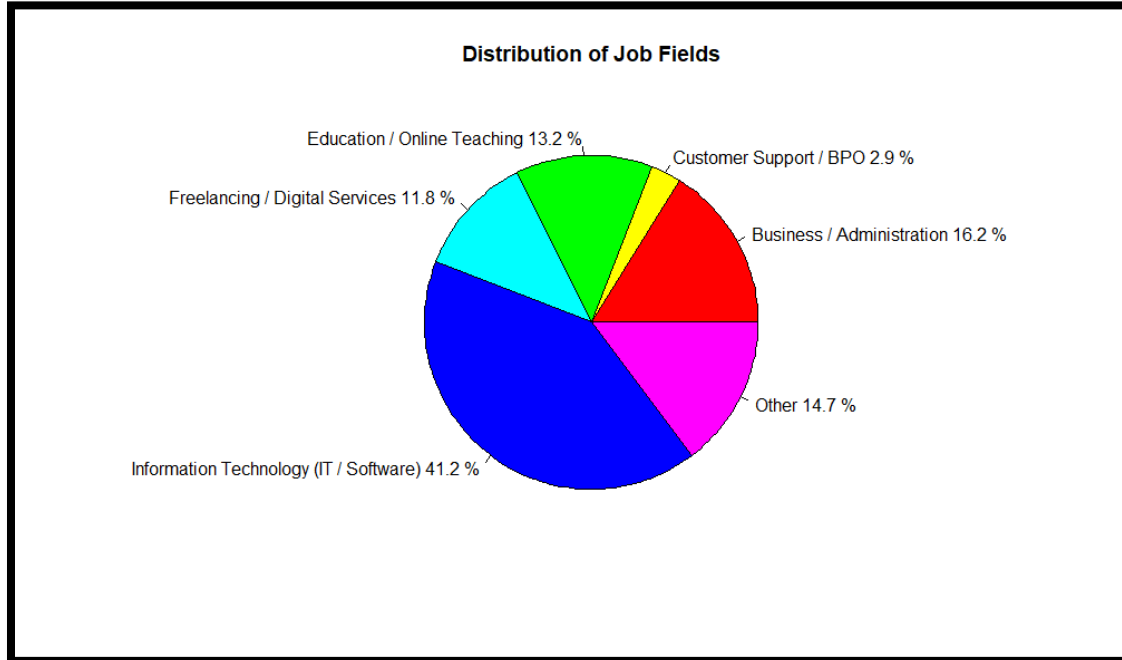


Figure 3/Distribution of job field Pie chart

The pie chart shows that Information Technology (IT/Software) is the dominant job field among the 68 remote workers, accounting for 41.2% of respondents, which is the highest share. The lowest segment is Customer Support/BPO at 2.9%, indicating that very few participants come from call-center style remote roles. Mid-sized groups include Business/Administration (16.2%), “Other” fields (14.7%), Education/Online Teaching (13.2%), and Freelancing/Digital Services (11.8%). This points to a growing tech-driven remote labor market in Sri Lanka. For this study, the distribution suggests the sample is strongly weighted toward knowledge-intensive, digitally enabled occupations, where remote work is already common and infrastructure demands (devices, internet, security) are higher. Therefore, conclusions may mainly reflect IT-oriented workers and should be generalized to other sectors with caution.

Province Distribution

```
> province_freq
  Central Province    Eastern Province North Central Province    Northern Province Sabaragamuwa Province    Southern Province    Uva Province
        31              2              10              2              2              2              4
  Western Province
        15
> |
```

Figure 4/Province frequency

```
province_percent
  Central Province    Eastern Province North Central Province    Northern Province Sabaragamuwa Province    Southern Province    Uva Province
    45.588235      2.941176      14.705882      2.941176      2.941176      2.941176      5.882353
  Western Province
    22.058824
> |
```

Figure 5/Province Percentage

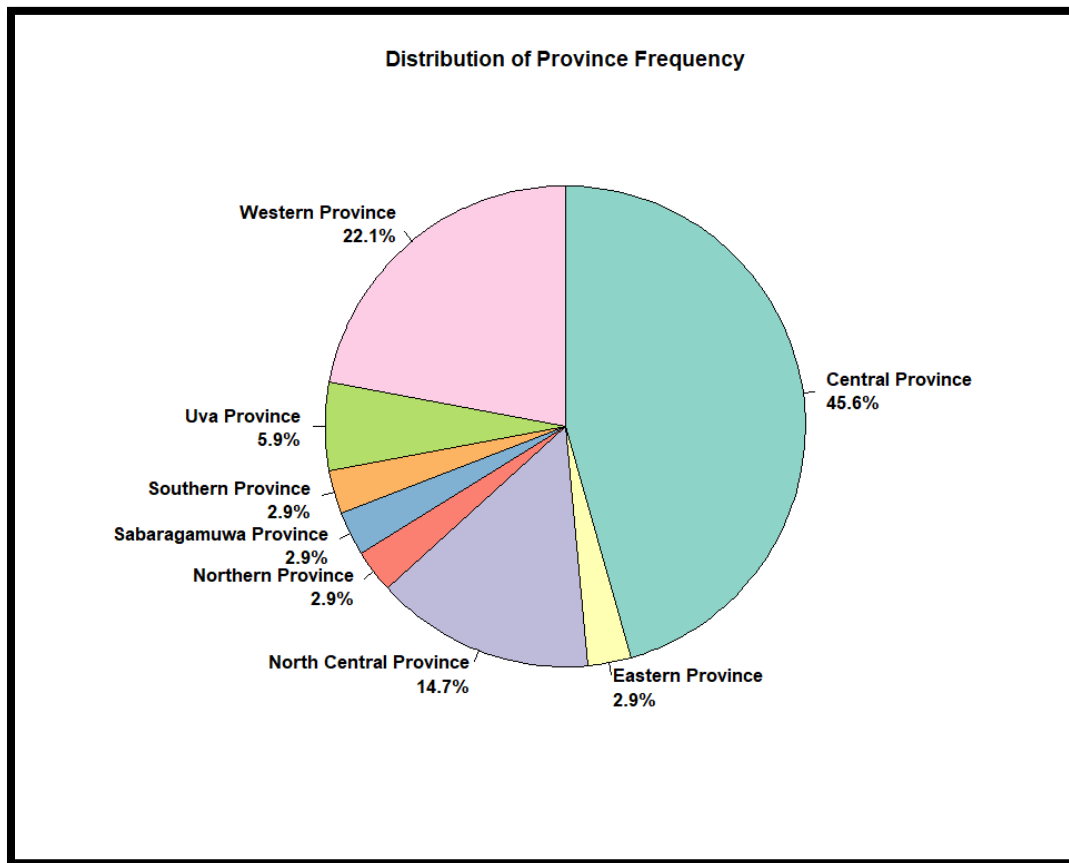


Figure 6/Distribution of Province frequency Pie chart

The pie chart illustrates the provincial distribution of the 68 remote workers in the sample. The Central Province has the largest share (45.6%), indicating that nearly half of the respondents are based in this region. The Western Province contributes the second-highest proportion at 22.1%, followed by the North Central Province (14.7%). Smaller shares come from Uva (5.9%), while Eastern, Northern, Sabaragamuwa, and Southern Provinces each account for 2.9% of responses. Overall, the data shows some geographic diversity, as participants represent multiple provinces across Sri Lanka. However, the distribution is not evenly spread, with a strong concentration in Central (and to a lesser extent Western) Province. This suggests the findings may reflect the experiences of remote workers in these dominant regions more strongly than those in underrepresented provinces.

Remote Work Experience

```
> experience_freq  
  
1 - 2 years      3 - 4 years  Less than 1 year  More than 4 years  
      23              7             31              7  
> |
```

Figure 7/Experience frequency

```
> experience_percent  
  
1 - 2 years      3 - 4 years  Less than 1 year  More than 4 years  
      33.82353      10.29412      45.58824      10.29412  
> |
```

Figure 8/Experience percentage

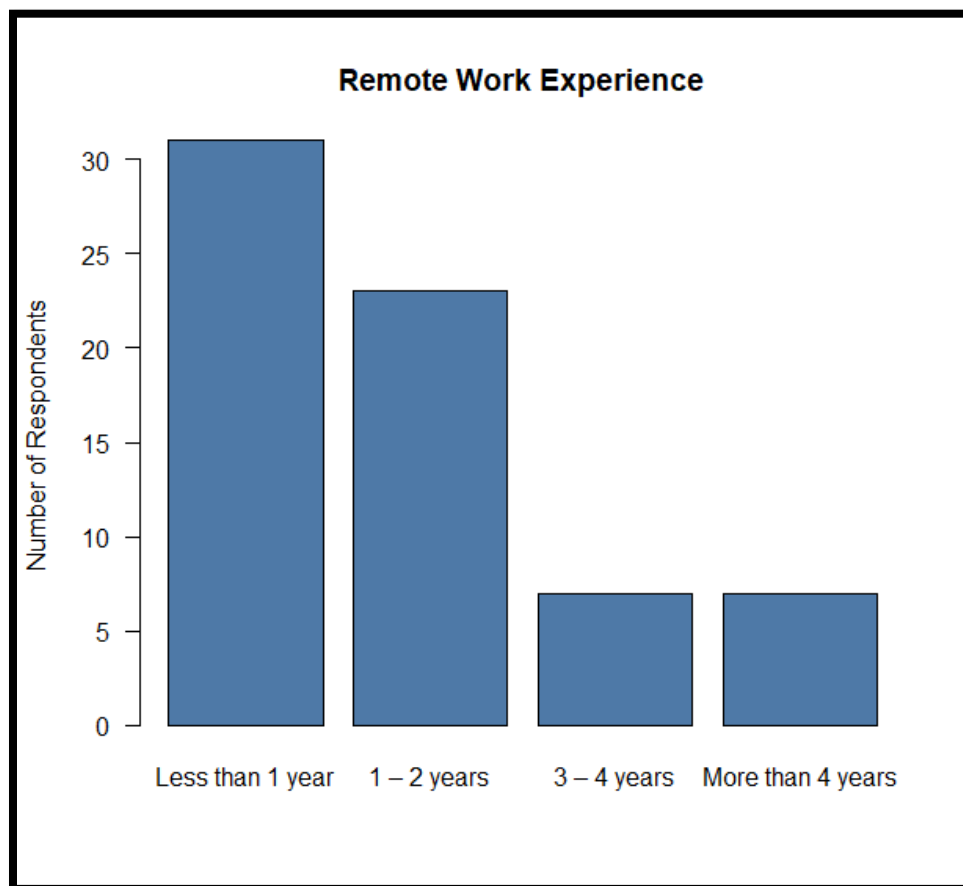


Figure 9/Remote work Experience Diagram

The bar graph summarizes respondents' remote work experience. The largest group falls under "Less than 1 year" (about 31 respondents), followed by "1- 2 years" (around 23 respondents). In contrast, only a small number report longer experience: approximately 7 respondents each in the "3 - 4 years" and "More than 4 years" categories. This indicates that the sample is dominated by relatively new remote workers, suggesting many participants may have entered remote work recently due to changing job markets and increased online opportunities. Although fewer respondents are long-term remote workers, the presence of participants with 3+ years of experience still provides valuable perspectives from more established remote work practices. Including both newer and more experienced workers strengthen reliability by capturing a wider range of adjustment stages, challenges, and coping strategies, reducing the chance that findings reflect only one experience level.

Monitoring Practices Among Remote Workers

Use of Digital Monitoring Tools

```
> monitoring_used
      No Not Sure      Yes
      10       7      51
> |
```

Figure 10/Monitoring used

```
> monitoring_percent
      No Not Sure      Yes
14.70588 10.29412 75.00000
> |
```

Figure 11Monitoring percentage

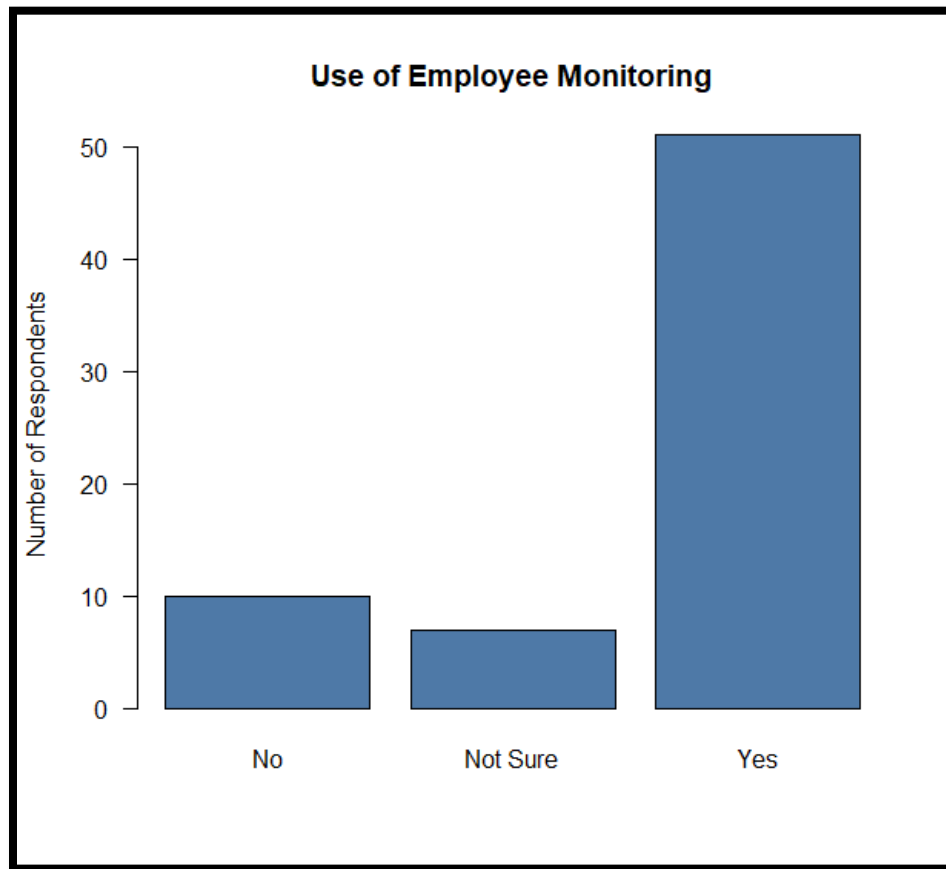


Figure 12/Use of Employee Monitoring Diagram

This bar graph shows that employee monitoring is common among the surveyed remote workers. Out of 68 respondents, 51 reported “Yes,” meaning about 75% are monitored in some form, while 10 reported “No” (14.7%) and 7 were “Not sure” (10.3%). The large gap between the “Yes” and “No” categories indicates that monitoring is not an occasional practice but a prevalent feature of remote work arrangements in this sample. The “Not sure” group also suggests that some monitoring may be indirect or not clearly communicated, highlighting possible transparency issues. It implies organizations rely on digital oversight to manage dispersed teams. For the study, this high prevalence supports investigating how monitoring relates to productivity, stress, privacy concerns, and trust between employees and employers in Sri Lanka’s remote-work context.

Type of Monitoring Used

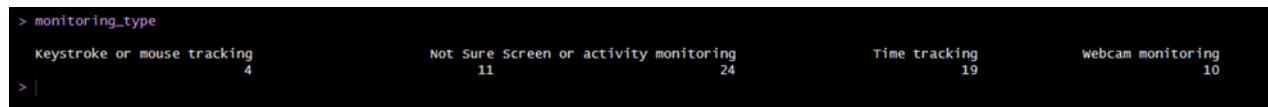


Figure 13/ Type of Monitoring Used

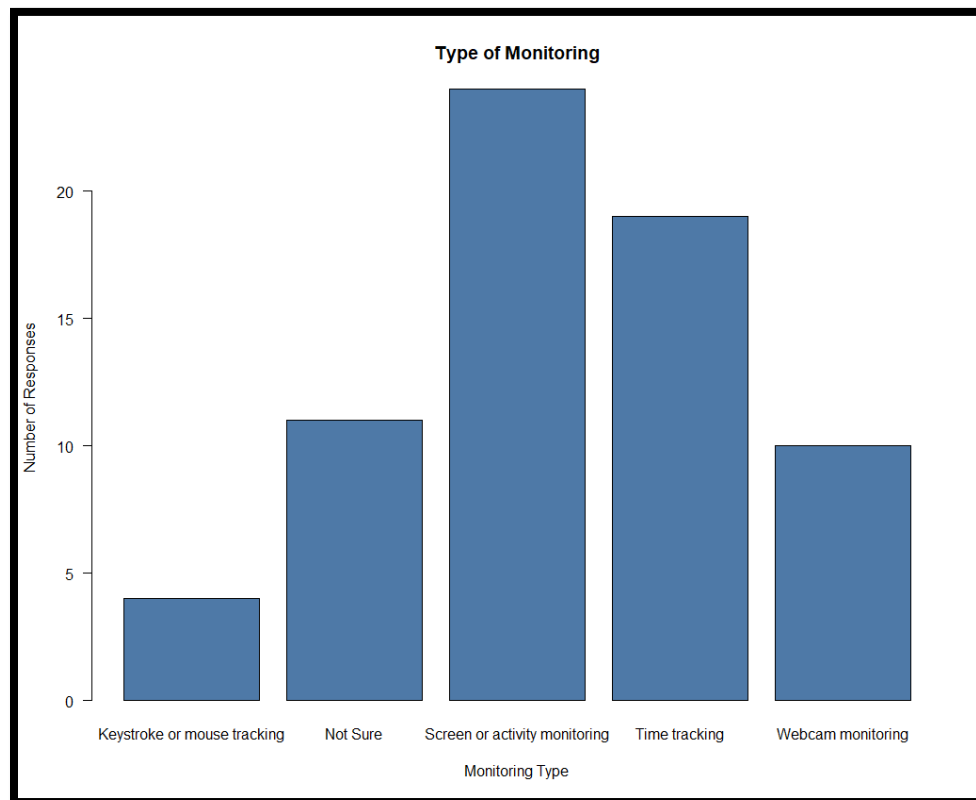


Figure 14/Type of monitoring Diagram

The bar graph indicates that the most common type of monitoring is screen or activity monitoring, reported by 24 respondents (35.3%), followed by time tracking with 19 respondents (27.9%). Webcam monitoring is also present (10 respondents, 14.7%), while keystroke or mouse tracking is relatively rare (4 respondents, 5.9%). The “Not sure” category (11 respondents, 16.2%) suggests that monitoring practices are not always clearly communicated. Overall, the dominance of screen/activity monitoring and time tracking implies a moderate-to-high level of managerial control, as these methods can observe work patterns and enforce accountability throughout the

day. At the same time, the low use of keystroke tracking may indicate that the most intrusive forms of surveillance are less common in this sample.

Monitoring Frequency

```
> monitoring_freq  
  
Always    Never    often    Rarely    Sometimes  
    20         5        19         7         17  
> |
```

Figure 15/Monitoring Frequency

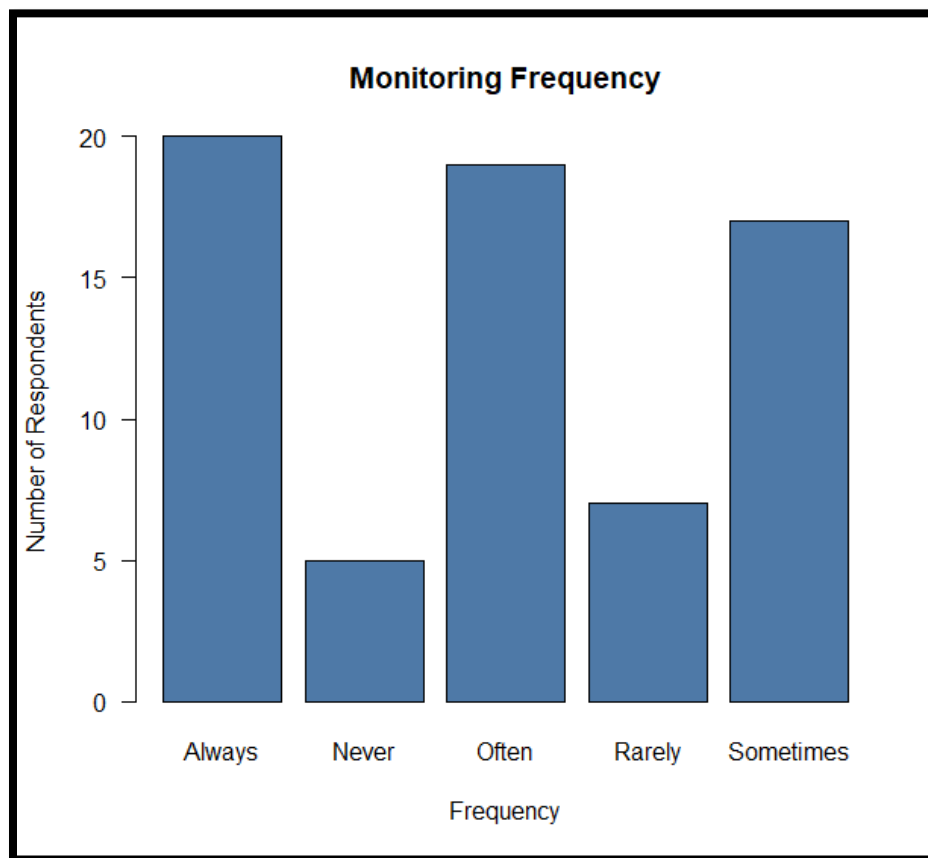


Figure 16/Monitoring Frequency Diagram

The bar graph shows that monitoring is largely frequent rather than occasional among the 68 remote workers. The biggest share report being monitored “Always” (20 respondents, 29.4%), closely followed by “Often” (19, 27.9%) and “Sometimes” (17, 25.0%). Only a smaller group experience monitoring “Rarely” (7, 10.3%), and very few say “Never” (5, 7.4%). Overall, this pattern suggests that for most respondents, monitoring is a regular part of remote work, with many experiencing it continuously or repeatedly during the week. Such high monitoring frequency can shape perceptions by reducing feelings of autonomy and increasing privacy or stress concerns, while also creating clearer accountability expectations and performance pressure. These mixed effects are important when interpreting attitudes toward remote work and employer trust.

Privacy and Trust Perceptions

Monitoring and Privacy Concerns

```
> table(df$Privacy)
Strongly Disagree    Disagree    Neutral    Agree    Strongly Agree
                2             0             15             36             15
> |
```

Figure 17/Privacy concerns

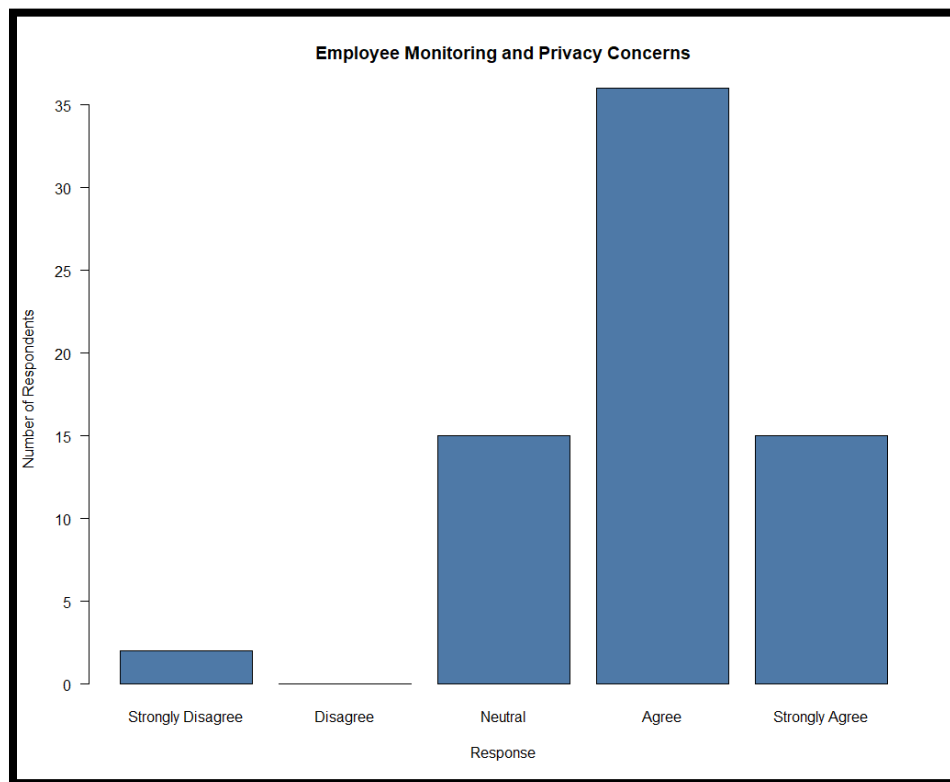


Figure 18/Employee Monitoring and privacy concerns Diagram

The bar graph indicates a clear tendency toward privacy concerns in relation to employee monitoring. Most respondents selected Agree (36) or Strongly Agree (15), totaling 51 out of 68 (about 75%) who feel monitoring raises privacy issues. Another 15 respondents were Neutral, suggesting some uncertainty or mixed experiences, while only 2 respondents Strongly Disagreed and virtually none chose Disagree. This strong skew toward agreement implies that privacy is a prominent theme in remote work settings, likely influenced by tools such as screen/activity

tracking and frequent supervision. For this study, this overall pattern supports the argument that monitoring practices can shape employee attitudes, trust, and well-being, and may contribute to stress or reduced autonomy even when monitoring is intended to improve accountability.

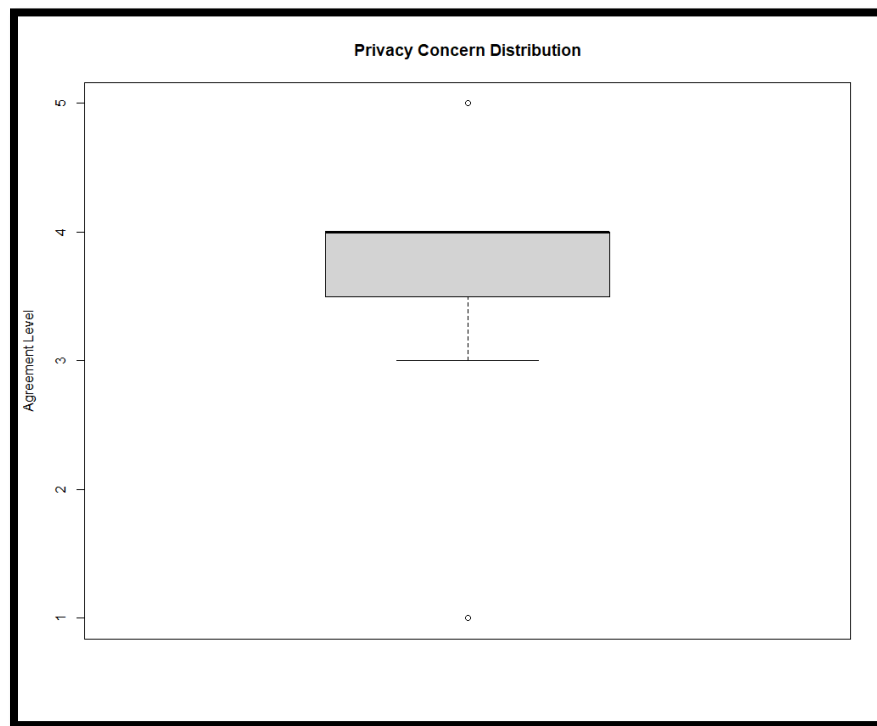


Figure 19/Box plot of Privacy concerns Distribution

The box plot summarizes the distribution of agreement levels (1–5) for privacy concerns. The median lies around 4 (Agree), meaning a typical respondent leans toward agreeing that monitoring creates privacy issues. The interquartile range (IQR) is relatively narrow roughly from 3.5 to 4.0 showing that the middle 50% of responses cluster between Neutral-to-Agree and Agree, with limited variability across participants. The whiskers extend down to about 3, indicating few low ratings, while isolated outliers appear near 1 and 5, representing a small minority with very low concern and another minority with extremely high concern. Overall, because the median is high and the spread is modest, the box plot suggests privacy concern is generally strong, not merely moderate, for most remote workers in this sample.

Trust in Ethical Use of Monitoring Data

```
> table(df$Trust)
Strongly Disagree    Disagree    Neutral    Agree    Strongly Agree
                1             1             27            36             3
> |
```

Figure 20/Trust in Ethical Use of Monitoring Data

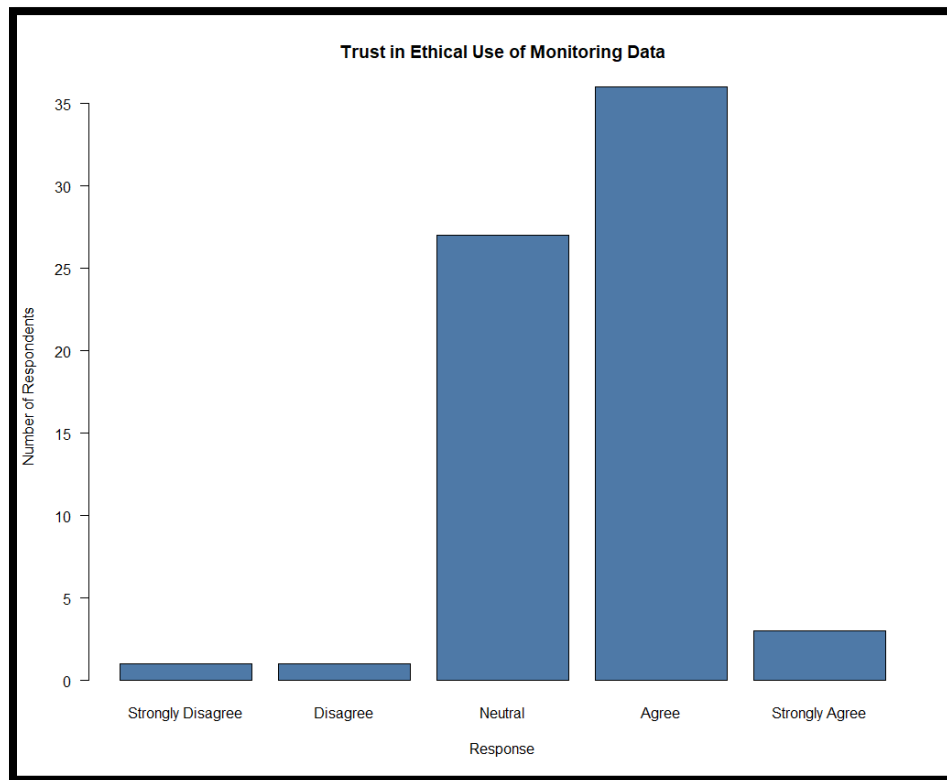


Figure 21/rust in Ethical Use of Monitoring Data Diagram

The bar graph shows that respondents generally have a positive level of trust in the ethical use of monitoring data. The largest group selected Agree (36 out of 68, 52.9%), while Strongly Agree is smaller (3, 4.4%). A substantial share chose Neutral (27, 39.7%), indicating many workers are uncertain and may trust only under clear rules, transparency, or consent. Very few expressed distrusts: Strongly Disagree (1, 1.5%) and Disagree (1, 1.5%). Overall, opinions are not sharply divided into two camps; instead, they lean toward trust with a large “undecided” middle. For this study, this suggests employees still need assurance about fairness, purpose limitation, and privacy protections, especially when monitoring is frequent or intrusive.

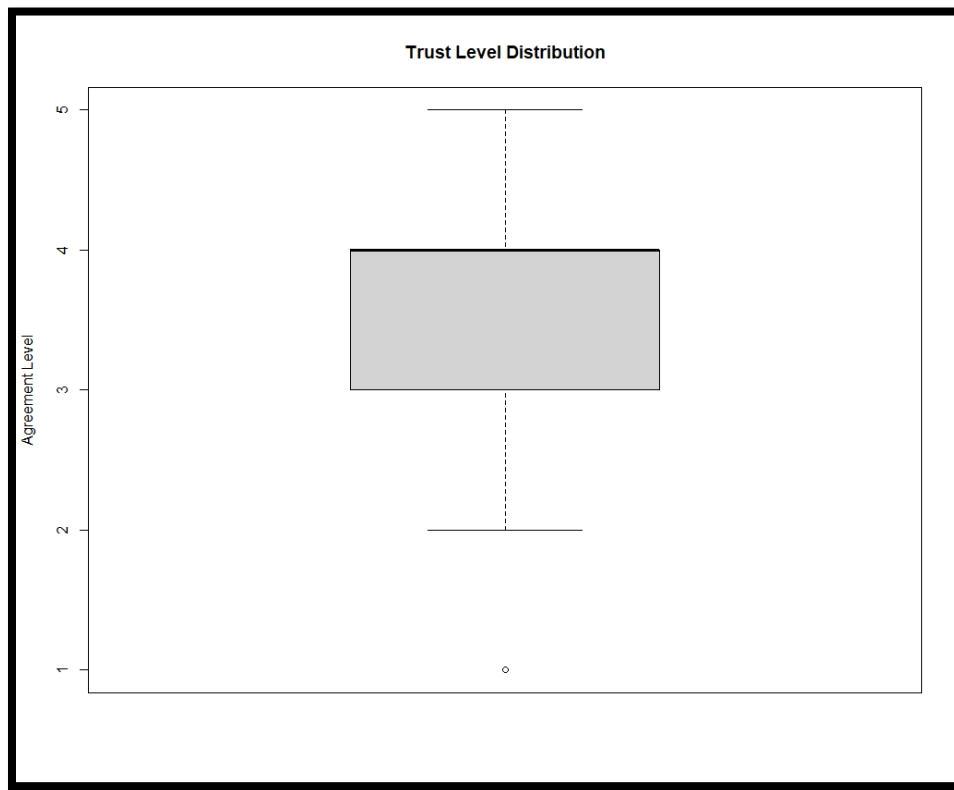


Figure 22/Box plot of Trust level Distribution

The box plot summarizes the same trust ratings (1–5) and shows where most responses concentrate. The median sits at about 4 (Agree), meaning the typical respondent leans toward trusting ethical use of monitoring data. The interquartile range (IQR) is roughly from 3 to 4, so the middle 50% of participants cluster between Neutral and Agree, which matches the large Neutral bar in the chart. The whiskers extend from about 2 up to 5, indicating some respondents report lower trust and a small group report very high trust. A single low outlier near 1 suggests isolated strong distrust. Overall, the spread is moderate rather than wide, implying opinions are fairly consistent and not strongly polarized, with trust often conditional on clear communication and ethical policies.

Impact of Monitoring on Productivity and Stress

Monitoring and Productivity

```
> table(df$Productivity)
Strongly Disagree    Disagree    Neutral    Agree    Strongly Agree
                1          16          30          19           2
> |
```

Figure 23/Monitoring and Productivity

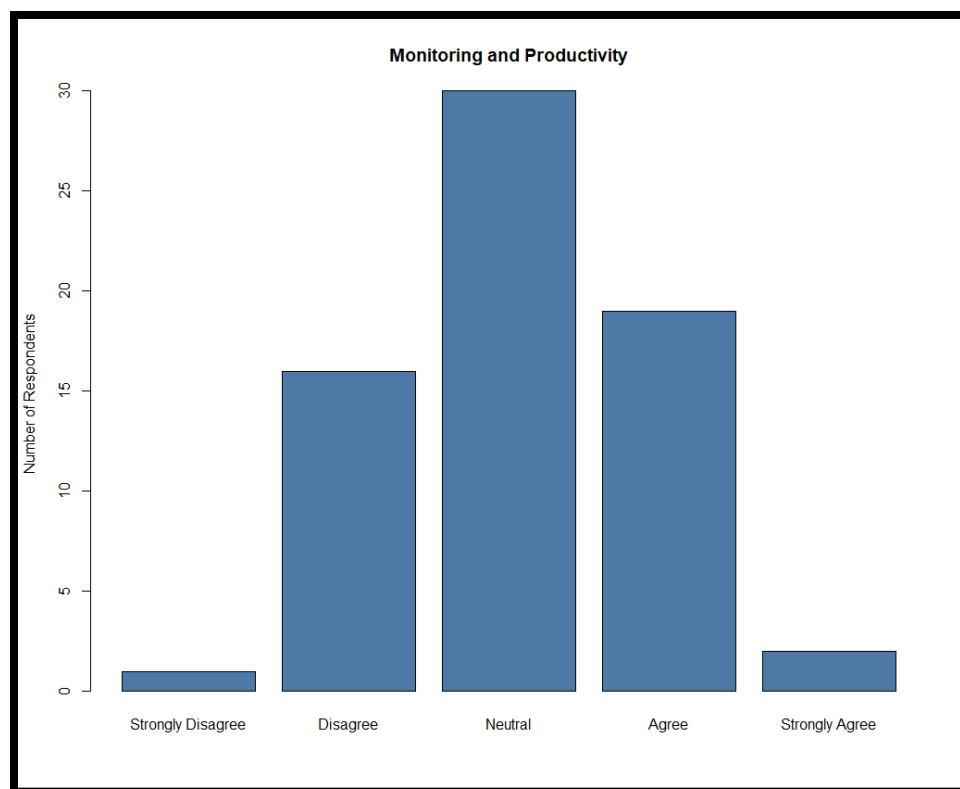


Figure 24/Monitoring and Productivity Diagram

The bar graph on Monitoring and Productivity shows that the most common response is Neutral (30 of 68, 44.1%), suggesting many workers are unsure whether monitoring actually boosts output. Positive views are present but not dominant: Agree (19, 27.9%) and Strongly Agree (2, 2.9%) together make 21 respondents (30.9%) who perceive productivity improvement. On the other hand, 16 (23.5%) Disagree and 1 (1.5%) Strongly Disagree, totaling 17 (25.0%), feel monitoring does not help. Only a very small minority strongly endorse it, indicating limited enthusiasm. Overall,

opinions are mixed, with a slight lean toward improvement but a large undecided group. For this study, this implies monitoring's productivity impact may depend on implementation style (supportive vs punitive) and on job type and autonomy.

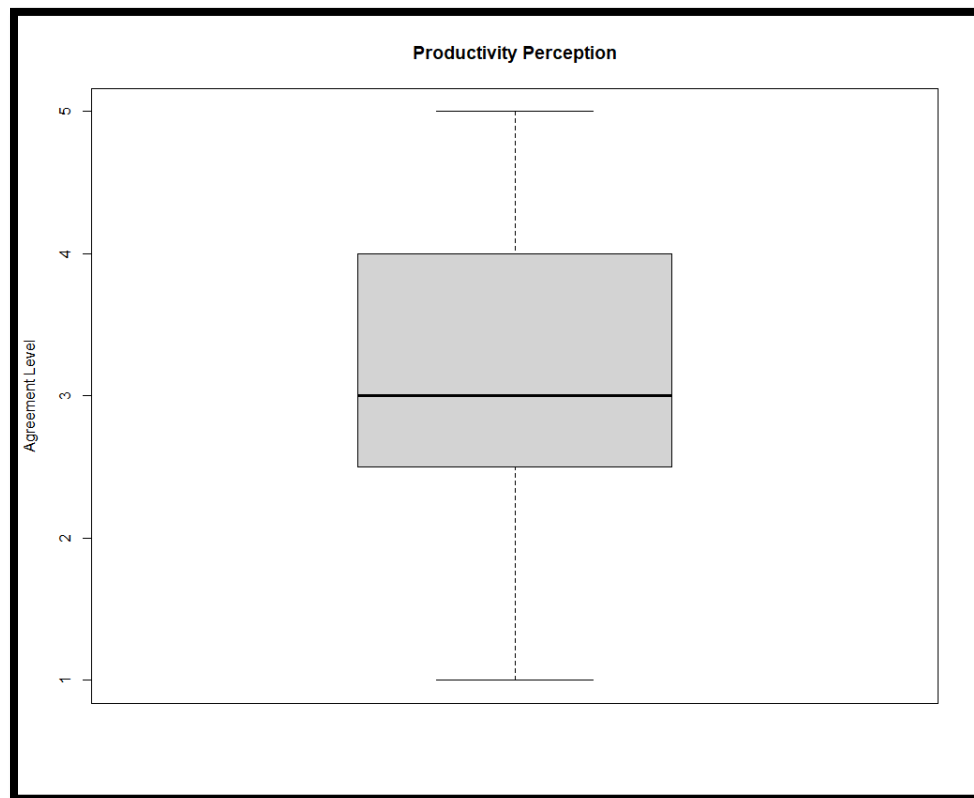


Figure 25/Box plot of Productivity Perception

The Productivity Perception box plot reinforces the lack of a clear consensus. The median line sits at about 3 (Neutral), meaning the typical respondent neither agrees nor disagrees that monitoring improves productivity. The box (IQR) spans roughly from 2.5 to 4.0, so the middle 50% of responses range from slightly negative to moderately positive, showing meaningful variability in experiences. The whiskers extend from 1 to 5, indicating that some participants strongly disagree while others strongly agree, even if those extremes are relatively few. This spread aligns with the large Neutral group in the bar chart. Because the distribution covers the full scale and the central tendency is neutral, monitoring can be interpreted very differently across workplaces. Overall, the box plot suggests productivity effects are mixed and context-dependent rather than uniformly positive.

Monitoring and Work Stress

```
> table(df$Stress)
Strongly Disagree    Disagree    Neutral    Agree    Strongly Agree
                   0         3        32        29         0
> |
```

Figure 26/Monitoring and Work Stress

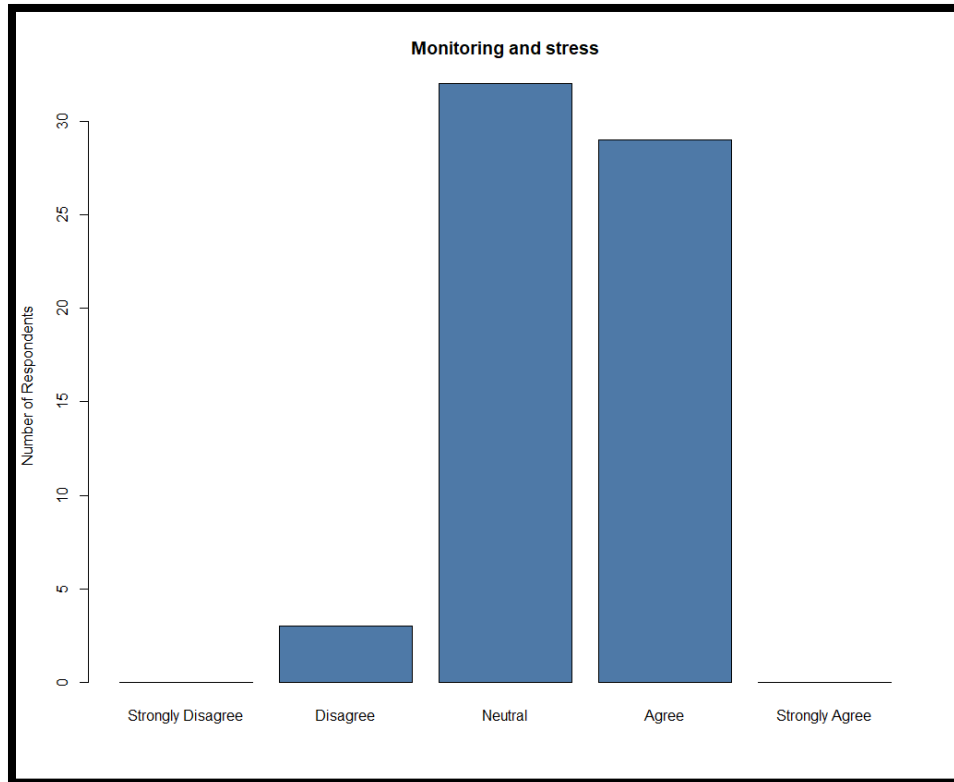


Figure 27/Monitoring and Work Stress Diagram

The bar graph on Monitoring and Stress suggests that monitoring is associated with higher stress for many respondents, but the strongest pattern is uncertainty. The most common response is Neutral (32 of 68, 47.1%), meaning nearly half neither agree nor disagree that monitoring increases stress. However, a large group selected Agree (29, 42.6%), indicating a substantial proportion feel monitoring does contribute to stress while working remotely. Only a small minority selected Disagree (3, 4.4%), and there are virtually no responses at the extreme ends (Strongly Disagree/Strongly Agree are near zero). Overall, the distribution leans toward stress increase, but the dominance of Neutral responses implies the stress impact may depend on factors such as

monitoring frequency, the type of tool used, workload expectations, and how managers communicate monitoring policies.

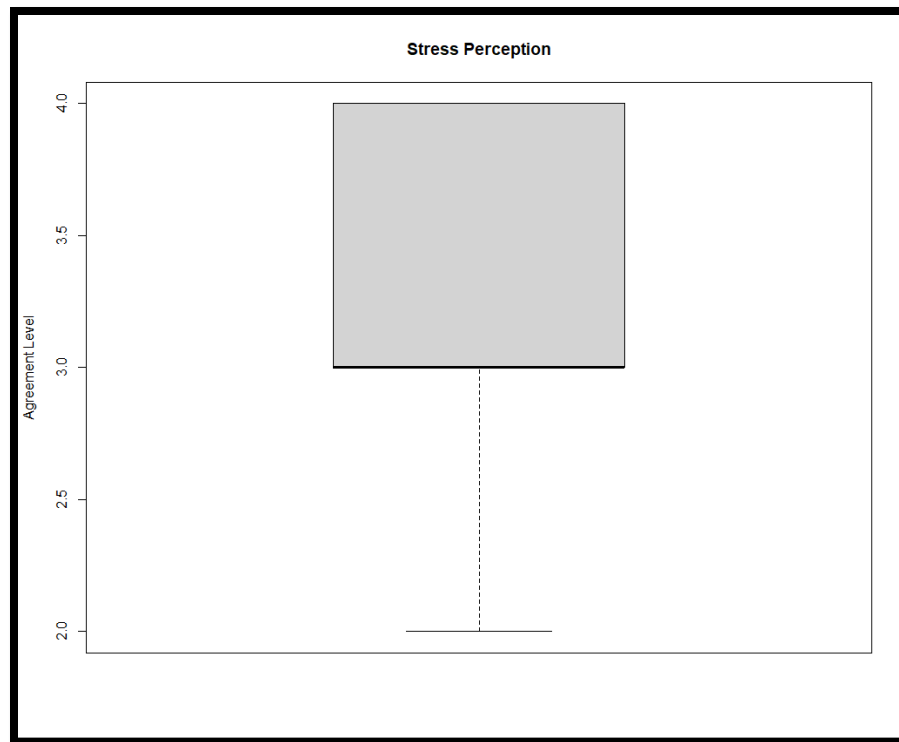


Figure 28/Box plot of stress perception

The Stress Perception box plot helps interpret variability in these views. The median sits around 3 (Neutral), consistent with the bar chart showing many undecided responses. The interquartile range (IQR) spans roughly from 3 to 4, meaning the middle 50% of respondents fall between Neutral and Agree a sign that stress concerns are fairly common but not universal. The lower whisker extends down to about 2, indicating some respondents lean toward disagreement, while the upper end is close to 4 with limited spread beyond it, suggesting few extreme “high-stress” ratings. Because the box is relatively compact and centered near Neutral-to-Agree, the overall interpretation is that monitoring tends to moderately increase stress for many workers, with limited polarization and only a small group reporting low stress effects.

Overall Impact on Work Performance

```
> table(df$Performance)
```

Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly Agree
0	27	23	17	0

```
> |
```

Figure 29/Overall Impact on Work Performance

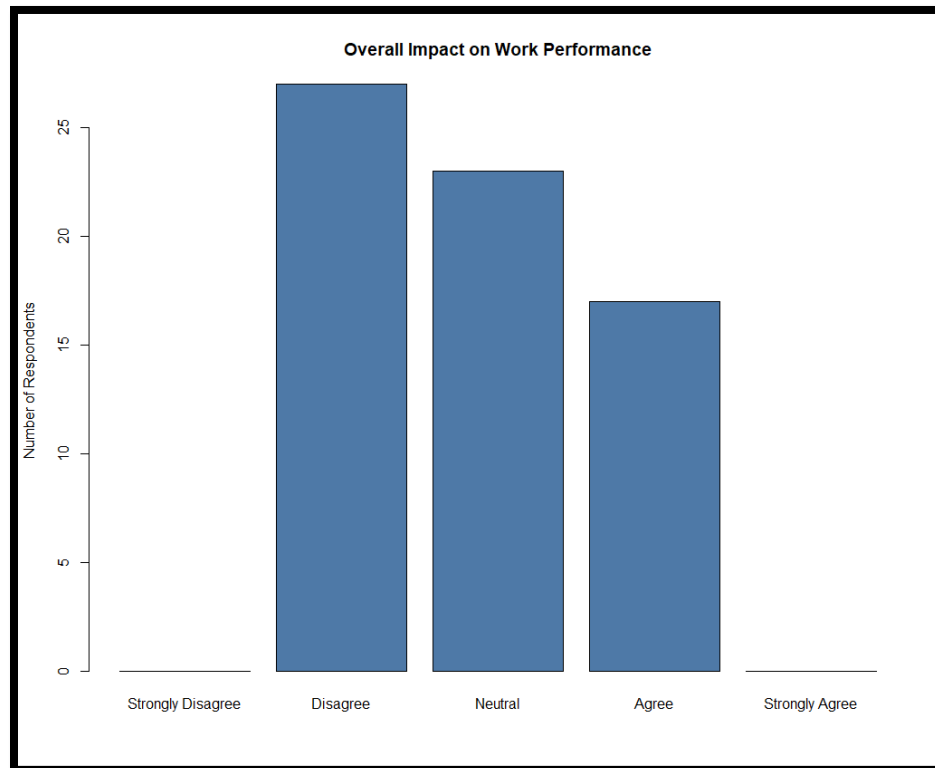


Figure 30/Overall Impact on Work Performance Diagram

The bar graph summarizes respondents' overall view of how monitoring affects work performance. The largest group selected "Disagree," followed by a substantial "Neutral" group, while a smaller portion selected "Agree." Very few (or none) chose the extreme options (Strongly Disagree/Strongly Agree), suggesting respondents are not highly polarized but tend to lean away from viewing monitoring as beneficial. Overall, the pattern indicates that monitoring is not perceived positively on average; many workers either feel it does not improve their performance or are unsure about its impact. For your study, this provides a clear final perception: although monitoring is widely used, employees do not strongly associate it with better performance, possibly because it creates pressure, reduces autonomy, or feels more controlling than supportive.

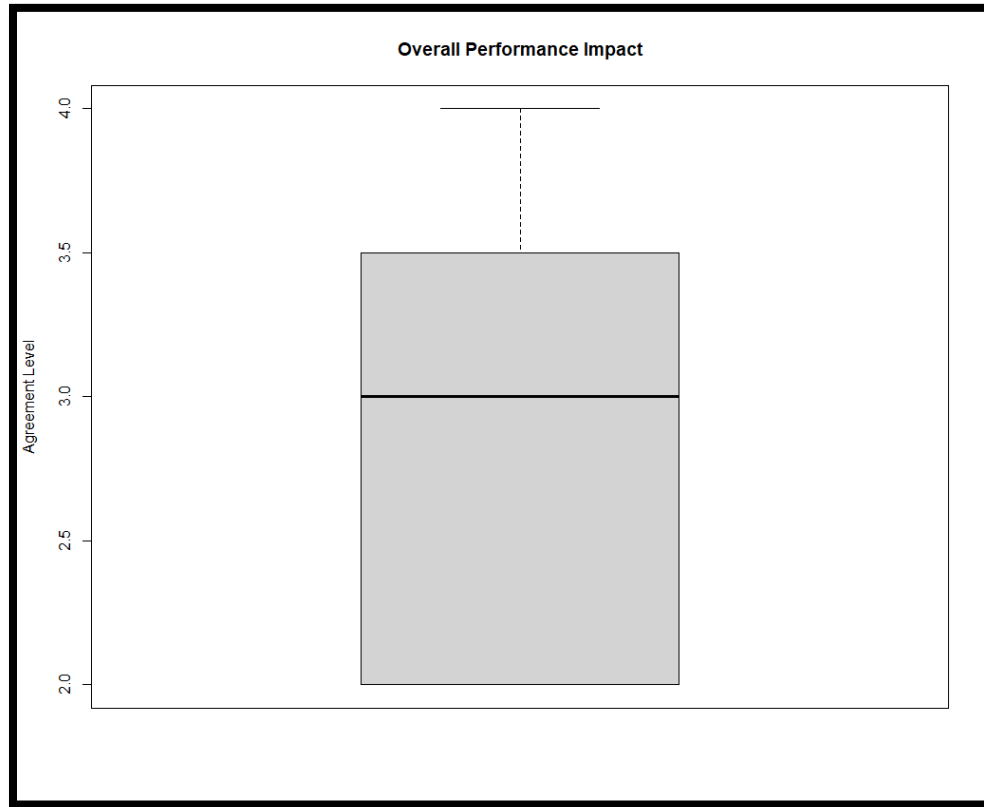


Figure 31/Box plot of overall performance impact

The box plot reinforces this overall conclusion by showing where responses cluster on the 1–5 agreement scale. The median sits around 3 (Neutral), meaning the typical respondent is undecided about whether monitoring improves performance. The interquartile range (IQR) spans roughly from 2 (Disagree) to about 3.5, indicating that the middle 50% of responses fall between negative and neutral perceptions. The upper whisker reaches close to 4 (Agree), showing that some respondents report a positive effect, but the distribution does not extend strongly toward the highest level. With most values concentrated below or around neutral, the box plot suggests monitoring is viewed more cautiously than positively overall, and perceived benefits are not consistent across workers.

Summary of Key Findings

This research studied how remote workers in Sri Lanka monitored and how it was seen to affect their privacy, trust, productivity, and stress. The results show that there are a number of significant trends among the surveyed participants.

To begin with, remote monitoring tools are common amongst the Sri Lankan remote workers. A strong majority of the respondents mentioned that they are monitored in some way, which shows that remote work arrangements have been heavily influenced by the feature of the digital oversight. Monitoring is not only present but common with many employees stating that they are monitored all time or frequently during working hours. This indicates that remote monitoring is not a one-time activity but a formal part of the managerial control of most organizations.

Second, screen or activity monitoring and time tracking are the most popular ones as far as the methods of monitoring are concerned. Greater intrusion like key strokes tracking does not seem to be prevalent in this sample. The fact that there is frequent monitoring and tracking of activities, however, indicates the employees are working under a well-structured digital oversight setting. There was also a noticeable percentage of the respondents who did not know the kind of monitoring that was applied, which could suggest the lack of transparency in informing about monitoring practices.

Third, the issue of privacy can be mentioned as one of the most powerful results of the research. A large proportion of participants concurred with the fact that the monitoring of employees has an impact on their privacy. The spread of the answers indicates that privacy issues do not belong to a small group of people but are common in the participants. This indicates that, despite accepting monitoring as a remote work provision, there is still a question of ethics in regard to the borders and autonomy of an individual.

Fourth, the moderation in trust in ethical usage of monitoring information is more moderate. Although a good part of the respondents stated that they believed that their organization can use monitoring data responsibly, a high proportion of the respondents answered that they are not sure. The respondents that highly distrusted were very few. It means that, even though employees can be worried about their privacy, they do not always think that organizations abuse data. Rather, trust seems to be conditional and can be based on transparency, equity, and explicit policies.

Fifth, there is an ambivalent view concerning the perceived effect of monitoring on productivity. Many of the respondents did not agree or disagree that monitoring enhances productivity, which is an indication that they do not know whether it does or not. Employees feel that performance is monitored which helps uphold discipline and accountability whereas others do not see the obvious performance benefits. The absence of a firm consensus means that productivity results can be subject to the implementation and management of monitoring.

Sixth, it seems that monitoring is moderately related to work-related stress. Though there were a high number of respondents who answered the question neutrally, there was a significant number of respondents who answered that monitoring causes stress. It is an indication that, though monitoring can increase accountability, it can also impose pressure and decrease a sense of autonomy. The results suggest that the effects of stress are moderate but not drastic and this is in accordance with the differences among various workplace settings and personal coping mechanisms.

Lastly, the general trend of the respondents on the overall effect of monitoring on work performance went towards a neutral to slightly negative effect. Monitoring is not regarded as being very effective in enhancing performance despite its general practice. This implies that as organizations implement monitoring systems to promote productivity and control the systems, employees might not always regard the systems as useful to their overall work performance.

In general, the results prove that the digital monitoring is common among the remote workers of Sri Lanka and correlates with serious privacy issues, moderate trust, mixed perceptions of the productivity, and observable effect of stress. It is based on these patterns that the following chapter further discusses the ethical implications and recommendations to interest in achieving balance between accountability and employee well-being.

Conclusion

The chapter gave the results, which are shown after the analysis of the data gathered among 68 remote employees in Sri Lanka through descriptive statistical techniques. The findings revealed that digital monitoring is a common phenomenon and is often implemented in a remote working environment, especially activity-tracking technology and time-monitoring software. Although several respondents were deeply concerned about the privacy issues, there was a moderate level of trust regarding the morality of monitoring data and a high percentage of those who were not particularly concerned. Perceived effects of monitoring on productivity were ambiguous, and some significant number of employees showed that they felt more stressed. Altogether, the results point out that despite the widespread use of monitoring, the benefits that this concept can bring are not always viewed as positive. These findings will be explained in the next chapter concerning the current literature and theoretical viewpoints and will be analyzed regarding their ethical and practical consequences.

Chapter 5

Discussion of Findings and Conclusion

Introduction

This chapter gives a detailed discussion about the findings of the research that were reported in Chapter 4. This discussion is intended to make sense of the empirical findings with reference to the literature that is already available, ethical theory, legal framework, and organizational governance principle. The chapter critically looks at the effects of employee monitoring system in relation to privacy, trust, productivity and work-related stress among remote workers in Sri Lanka.

The discussion combines the national and international principles in data protection, labor protection principles, and ethical Business Information Systems (BIS) governance concepts to determine whether the current monitoring practices are in accord with responsible digital management. In addition, the Social Exchange Theory is utilized to theoretically justify the reaction of employees to monitoring practices.

The chapter finishes with the description of the practical implications to the organizations in Sri Lanka and provides the general synthesis of the contributions of the study.

Discussion of Demographic Context

The demographic characteristics of the respondents offer sufficient background of the finding's interpretation. A large percentage of the respondents worked in the IT and technology-based industries. This is indicative of the overall economic situation of Sri Lanka in which digital enabled industries have experienced the greatest adoption of remote work. The issue of the concentration of respondents in the Western and Central provinces also fits the national trends of infrastructure and technological access. (Remote and Flexible Work Options, n.d.)

Most of the respondents had a length of less than two years of remote working experience. It is an indication that practice of remote work in Sri Lanka is still developing and that a significant

number of employees are still acclimatizing to the digital work systems. The newer remote workers can be more uncertain about the organizational policies, especially those which are associated with monitoring and online supervision. (Priyantha, 2026)

The digital literacy and the relatively young age of the sample is important. More so, technology focused employees tend to be more enlightened on the issues surrounding digital privacy and can be even more sensitive to the data collection practices. Thus, the issues of privacy, which are exhibited in the results, might not be merely the responses to the monitoring itself but could be the manifestations of the knowledge of the digital rights.

Also, the sizes of organizations distribution indicates that monitoring practices can differ in different institutional settings. The bigger organizations might use standardized tools of digital oversight embedded in enterprise systems, but the smaller organizations might use monitoring less formal. Nevertheless, the popularity of surveillance among demographics signifies that employee surveillance is being normalized under the Sri Lankan remote work environment.

The population background thus positions the results as indicative of an expanding, technologically focused remote workforce who is not only digitally skilled but also digitally conscious. (Sri Lanka's Growing Remote Work Ecosystem, 2024)

Prevalence of Monitoring and Ethical Implications

The results indicate that employee surveillance is a common practice among the Sri Lankan remote employees. About three-quarters of the surveyed respondents said that they are monitored in one way or another. Moreover, the frequency of monitoring seems to be regular or continuous in most of the organizations. (Khrystenko, 2026)

This mass adoption means that electronic surveillance is now integrated in organizational operations instead of a token management instrument. Activity tracking, screen logs, system usage reports and time-tracking programs seem to be part and parcel of Business Information Systems (BIS) systems. (Sri Lanka's Growing Remote Work Ecosystem, 2024)

Ethically speaking, the normalization of monitoring provokes several questions of a certain importance. Although there are valid interests of organizations in holding the accountability,

performance management, and data security, ethical considerations occur when excessive, intrusive, or poorly communicated oversight is enforced.

Here the principle of proportionality comes into the fore. It has to be proportional between the organization goal that it is supposed to monitor. Continuous monitoring particularly when it takes detailed behavioral data may be more than what is required to perform performance evaluation.

Moreover, the integration of monitoring in the main information systems will expose the oversight to the search of making routine. Digital monitoring can be conducted invisibly and continuously unlike the traditional workplace supervision, and this can lead to an escalation of the feeling of surveillance by employees. (J., 2024)

Such environments could be ethically lowering autonomy. Innovation and knowledge-based industries, autonomy is an important factor as productivity comes with intrinsic motivation. This motivation can be accidentally destroyed by excessive supervision, despite performance indicators seeming to be in check.

The results can be interpreted to mean that the monitoring practices in Sri Lanka have evolved at a fast rate perhaps considering that the focus has not been placed equally on the governance structures, ethical training, or the refinement of the policies. This requires further organizational introspection of the tradeoff between technological capacity and ethics.

Privacy Concerns and Legal Protections

One of the most dominant themes in the study turned out to be privacy. A large proportion of the surveyed people were also worried that they are being monitored at the expense of their personal privacy. This issue has been of his special concern in the area of remote working when work activity is performed in home environments.

Contrary to the usual office setting, remote working erases the lines between personal and work worlds. Surveillance tools that collect screen shots, internet use or even webcam communications might unintentionally expand into personal areas.

The section explains the findings using pertinent legal and regulatory frameworks.

- Discussion under the Sri Lankan Personal Data Protection Framework (PDPA)

The Sri Lankan data protection system focuses on the legal processing of data, its limitation by purpose, minimization of data, its accuracy, limitation in storage, and security measures. Such principles demand that the organizations should only gather and use personal data where there is an actual need and a well-defined purpose. (Data protection laws in Sri Lanka, n.d.)

The results showed that there was an appreciable proportion of the employees who did not know the exact nature of monitoring employed. This ambiguity brings about issues of transparency requirements. When organizations fail to explicitly communicate to the employees how their data is gathered and processed, they are in danger of making non-disclosure to the requirements of transparency.

Moreover, high-frequency monitoring can also be inconsistent with the principles of data minimization in case more information is gathered than needed to serve the legitimate business purpose. An example is elaborate recording of keystroke or continuous taking of screenshots possible far beyond what is required to quantify task accomplishment. (Government, 2022)

Legal compliance thus is not just determined by the presence of monitoring policies but equally on clarity, communication and proportional implementation.

- Discussion under International Data Protection Standards (GDPR Principles)

The European General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) is generally considered as the international standard of governance on the issue of data protection. Its principles are on consent, legal basis of processing, accountability and respect of individual rights. (Comparing the Sri Lankan Personal Data Protection Bill, 2019 and the GDPR, n.d.)

Though the jurisdiction of GDPR may not apply to all the Sri Lankan organizations, the standards direct the world digital governance practices, especially in multinational or cross-border affairs.

Within the logic of GDPR, the employee monitoring should reflect the legitimate interest, and it should not supplant the individual rights. The employers have to make sure that surveillance devices are justifiable, reasonable, and open.

The fact that highly intrusive measures like webcam surveillance or keystroke logging have not been widely adopted in the results can possibly indicate that the findings aspect is partially aligned with the principles of proportionality. Nevertheless, even frequent monitoring of activities requires an explanation and written protection.

The significance of the data subject rights, such as access to personal data and the right to demand corrections, is supported by GDPR, too. Companies that adopt monitoring systems should make sure that there are systems in place that allow workers to access and comprehend data that is being gathered.

Therefore, the privacy issues identified in this research indicate that it is necessary to harmonize local practice with international standards of digital governance.

- Discussion under Labor Protection Principles

The concepts of labor protection focus on the dignity of the worker, equality, and hygiene at work. The field of psychological well-being is becoming a subset of occupational health.

Constant and or over-monitoring can cause pressure that affects mental health. The results show that the impact of stress on monitoring practices is moderate, which implies that monitoring using digital technologies can indirectly influence employee health. (Sri Lanka Labor Regulations, n.d.)

Workplace structures normally provide those workplaces should not lead to harm, both physical and mental in nature. This is why the monitoring systems have to be analyzed with references to the productivity results as well as to the possible emotional consequences.

A duty of care makes employers make sure that monitoring practices do not form fear, anxiety, and undue pressure on performance.

- Discussion under Ethical BIS Governance

In addition to the compliance with the law, Business Information Systems governance structures should be considered in relation to ethical evaluation. Ethical BIS governance is the design, implementation, and management of information systems in the manner that incorporates a sense

of fairness, accountability, and transparency. (Digital Ethics in Action: A Guide to Ethical Employee Monitoring Practices, 2024)

Monitoring tools are not just managerial tools, but technological systems written, coded and connected in organizational structures. Thus, not only management is ethically responsible but system designers and administrators are also.

The results indicate that the idea of monitoring is internally embedded in working processes. There are a few fundamental principles, which are to be used in ethical governance.

Table 2/ Discussion of Findings /Ethical BIS Governing Employee Monitoring Systems

Proportionality	The systems are supposed to gather information only required to achieve established goals.
Transparency	The employees are to be well aware of the scope and purpose of monitoring.
Privacy by Design	Ethical considerations ought to be instilled during the system development phase as opposed to being introduced subsequent to deployment.
Accountability	Review and auditing of practices should be carried out at regular time intervals to avoid misuse or mission creep.
Employee Involvement	Employees are supposed to be consulted on the issue of digital oversight policy.

The concept of ethical BIS governance is that it does not emphasize the technological capability but rather responsible design. To achieve sustainable digital workplaces, there must be the balance between managerial control and respect towards human dignity. (David, 2025)

Trust and Transparency in Monitoring Systems

Relationships in organizations are based on trust as a key dimension. The results demonstrate the medium levels of trust to monitoring systems where numerous respondents have expressed neutral attitudes.

This indifference implies that there is uncertainty instead of confidence. Transparency has a big role in the trust in digital systems. Employees will find oversight more acceptable when organizations explain why the monitoring is necessary and how the data will be utilized.

Monitoring, however, can be viewed as distrust when the communication is not much. Even due to lawful practices, surveillance signals can produce influence on psychological perceptions. (Samaranayake, V & Gamage, C, 2012)

Long-term commitment of the employees also affects trust. When the workers feel that they are being monitored too much or unfairly, organizational loyalty can be lost. On the other hand, ethical governance and open dialogue can support commitment.

Therefore, the transparent policies, grievance systems, and the boundaries should be provided along with monitoring systems. (Deshapriya. D.C. & Jayasinghe, C., 2025)

Monitoring and Productivity: Efficiency vs Autonomy

The research found out that there are ambivalent attitudes as to productivity improvement. Once more, many of the respondents chose neutral answers; this shows that monitoring does not necessarily mean performance improvement.

Knowledge-based workplaces require autonomy, creativity, and intrinsic motivation in order to be productive. Over monitoring can lead to less freedom to think and cause the pressure that inhibits deep work. (Best Employee Productivity Measurement Tools in Sri Lanka, 2025)

Although accountability measures can be useful in minimizing time wastage, they can also create compliance-based performance as opposed to productivity that is based on innovation.

The results hence uphold the thesis that the gains in efficiency should be measured together with the considerations of autonomy. Goal-based performance evaluation can be even more beneficial to organizations than behavioral tracking. (Monitoring employee productivity: A complete guide, n.d.)

More balance may be attained by monitoring systems that concentrate on outcomes, as opposed to micro-behaviors.

Monitoring and Work Stress: Ethical Risk Assessment

The findings show that there are moderate stress levels related to monitoring practices. Even though the cases of extreme stress were not rampant, cumulative effects on the psychological impact are to be taken into account.

The self-consciousness and performance anxiety might be a result of constant visibility. Workers who perceive that their performance is constantly assessed might not be able to take a mental break at work. (Viraj Samaranayake, et al., 2012)

The risk assessment models used in ethics suggest that the possibility of unintended effects of technological systems should be evaluated. Psychological impact testing should be used to assess monitoring tools as is the case with occupational risks evaluation.

When monitoring is an element of stress that cannot be obviously productive, then organizations need to review the breadth and frequency of monitoring. (Jayasinghe, Y. C. S. K & Wanigasekara, W. M. S. K., 2022)

Remote work will need sustainability in the long term that relies on the welfare of the employees.

Theoretical Discussion Using Social Exchange Theory and Professional Ethical Standards

The Social Exchange Theory offers an effective explanatory framework to explain the employee responses to the digital monitoring in remote working environments. According to the theory, workplace relations are organized on mutual exchange where trust, fairness, and a sense of obligation are the building block of a sustainable relationship. Facilitation actions by the company are viewed by the employees as indicators of relation. Once they see respect and fairness, they give back with loyalty, commitment and better performance. On the other hand, in situations where they suspect or feel mistreated, they can fight by being less engaged, they can be psychologically withdrawn or can show less compliance.

In the framework of the present research, monitoring systems are not only devices that work as technical means but rather as a symbolic system that conveys the intent of the managerial communication. Regular or invasive digital monitoring can be an indication of mistrust, though it can be used on valid performance grounds. Such signals according to Social Exchange Theory affect employee perceptions of relational balance. In the event that monitoring is construed as an indicator that the management believes that employees will not perform well without monitoring, then the psychological contract between the employer and the employee could be violated. (Yasangi Anuradha Iddagoda & Henarath H. D. N. P. Opatha, 2020)

Results of this research show equivocal productivity results and conditional trust. This is in line with the prediction of the theory that reciprocity is very much reliant on the perceived fairness. Employees might consider transparent monitoring as an element of professional accountability under conditions of its justification. Nevertheless, in cases where communication becomes ambiguous or where supervision seems overboard the employees may doubt the motives of the manager. This awareness affects the behavioral reactions, such as a decrease in the level of intrinsic motivation or augmentation of stress.

Notably, Social Exchange Theory is not limited to emotional response; however, it touches upon the issue of power asymmetry in organizations. The monitoring systems increase managerial visibility and control and reduce the privacy of the employees. This imbalance reconstructs the relationship of exchange. Employees can feel that the relationship has changed focus to a surveillance-based compliance than to trust-based cooperation. In the long run, these dynamics

have the potential of changing the organizational culture towards a more control-dominated form, as opposed to the relationship-based cooperation. (Jose, et al., 2012)

In order to further elaborate this theoretical argument, professional codes of ethics should also be taken into consideration especially the principles in the IEEE Code of Ethics. Ethical responsibility is not just a managerial-level policy but also a technological design and professionalism since monitoring systems are built, deployed, and sustained by information system professionals and corporate leaders.

IEEE Code of Ethics is based on the principles of honesty, transparency, fairness, harm avoidance, and privacy. These values are quite applicable to remote employee surveillance systems. On the other hand, the IEEE guidelines emphasize that professionals must not, through false or malicious act, hurt other individuals, their property, character or job. In its application to monitoring technologies, the principle can be understood to mean that system designers and managers need to make sure that the data that is gathered is correct, contextualized and not misconstrued to the detriment of employees who are not properly disadvantaged by this.

In the same way, the IEEE Code urges professionals to be truthful and be realistic with the claims or estimates. Organizations should not exaggerate the productivity advantages of surveillance tools in cases where surveillance is being used in monitoring. When the monitoring systems are being introduced as performance-enhancing tools and fail to deliver any tangible results, at the same time raising the level of stress, the morality of their further use becomes weakened. (IEEE Code of Ethics, n.d.)

The other important IEEE principle is connected with the privacy respect and confidentiality. Monitoring systems often utilize behavioral information, logs of system usage and performance. To achieve ethical implementation, this data should only be accessible to authorized persons and cannot be used secondarily to achieve other purposes that are not related to performance appraisal. Sharing or reassuring monitoring data would be against the professional ethics and destroy relational trust as expected by the Social Exchange Theory.

Accountability and responsibility in the making of technological decisions is also highlighted in the IEEE Code. The engineers and system administrators should be able to predict the predictable implications of the technologies they are putting in place. Psychological stress, loss of trust, and

lack of autonomy are some of the risks that can be anticipated in the remote work environment. This makes ethical responsibility to involve impact assessment prior to and after monitoring deployment. Such effects should not be overlooked since it would be against the scope of professional duties to cause minimal harm. (IEEE Code of Ethics, n.d.)

A combination of IEEE ethical standards and Social Exchange Theory makes the theoretical understanding deeper as the concept of relational dynamics is related to professional responsibility. The social Exchange Theory is what makes employees act in specific ways in response to monitoring and the IEEE code is what clarifies the way monitoring systems should be ethically designed and regulated. (IEEE Code of Ethics, n.d.)

The contradictory productivity and moderate stress levels results of this research imply that monitoring systems have complex relational impacts. When done in relative proportions and openly, they can support accountability without destroying trust. Nevertheless, whenever professionals fail to adhere to ethical design concepts, monitoring may imply suspicion hence, disrupting mutual interactions.

Moreover, the Social Exchange Theory suggests that it will have long-term repercussions. Compliance can be short-term in the form of intensive monitoring but the long-term performance will need relational trust. This is strengthened by the IEEE ethical standards that offer priorities in regard to integrity, respect, and harm avoidance in technology systems. In the event that these standards inform the execution of monitoring, organizations stand a better chance of attaining operational effectiveness as well as relational equilibrium. (Code of Ethics, n.d.)

As such, monitoring systems cannot be only judged using technical performance metrics. They also have to be explored as moral artifacts that are incorporated in the relations of social exchange. Through the harmonization of monitoring practices based on the IEEE principle of ethics especially transparency, fairness and respect of privacy, organizations can maintain the mutual trust at the core of their working relationships. (IEEE Code of Ethics, n.d.)

Finally, Social Exchange Theory shows that the attitude of employees with respect to monitoring perceived fairness and relational balance. This analysis is reinforced by the IEEE Code of Ethics which provides professional requirements of designing and implementing ethical systems. Collectively, these structures highlight the importance of being able to balance the technical

capacity of technology with the social trustworthiness of relationships as a means of ensuring responsible digital governance. Monitoring systems do not only affect the productivity measures but also have an impact on the moral structure of organizational relationships.

Practical Implications for Sri Lankan Organizations

The findings of this research show several important practical implications for organizations in Sri Lanka that are using, or planning to use, employee monitoring systems in remote work settings. The results show concerns about privacy, trust, stress, and the unclear effect of monitoring on productivity. Because of this, organizations should not depend only on technical control systems. Instead, they should follow ethical and responsible management practices. Monitoring should not be seen only as a management tool, but as part of a wider digital governance system that must balance organizational needs with employee dignity and well-being.

1) Develop clear written monitoring policies.

Organizations should create clear written policies about employee monitoring. These policies should explain what type of monitoring is used, why it is needed, what kind of data is collected, how often monitoring happens, who can see the data, and how long it will be kept. Clear policies can reduce confusion and improve transparency.

2) Conduct employee awareness sessions explaining monitoring purposes.

Organizations should conduct awareness and communication sessions for employees about monitoring practices. The findings suggest that when employees do not fully understand monitoring systems, trust can decrease. Therefore, organizations should clearly explain the purpose, scope, and limits of monitoring. Good communication can reduce the feeling that monitoring is hidden or unfair.

3) Implement data minimization and retention controls.

Organizations should follow data minimization and data retention principles. This means they should collect only the data that is truly necessary for business purposes. Unnecessary screenshots,

constant tracking, or very detailed behavior monitoring should be avoided unless there is a strong reason for them. Also, data should not be kept for longer than necessary, and it should be properly protected from misuse.

4) Establish internal governance committees to oversee digital ethics.

Sri Lankan organizations should set up internal oversight systems to check the ethical use of monitoring tools. This could include a digital ethics committee, an HR and IT review panel, or regular monitoring audits. These systems can help make sure that monitoring is fair, reasonable, transparent, and consistent with organizational values. They are also important for preventing monitoring from becoming more intrusive over time.

5) Periodically assess psychological impact and stress indicators.

Organizations should regularly check the psychological effects of monitoring on employees. The study found that monitoring is linked with moderate stress. This means employers should understand that surveillance can affect employee mental well-being even if productivity does not improve clearly. Employee surveys, well-being checks, and confidential complaint systems can help organizations identify problems early.

6) Shift from behavioral micro-monitoring to performance outcome evaluation.

Organizations should move from micro-monitoring employee behavior to evaluating work outcomes. The findings of this study suggest that frequent monitoring does not always improve productivity. In knowledge-based work, productivity often depends more on trust, autonomy, and clear goals than on constant supervision. Therefore, organizations should focus more on results such as task completion, quality of work, deadlines, and goal achievement rather than tracking every small activity.

7) Integrate employee feedback mechanisms into BIS governance.

Organizations should include employee feedback in the management of monitoring systems. Employees should have chances to share their concerns, give suggestions, and take part in discussions about monitoring policies. This can improve fairness, increase employee acceptance, and strengthen trust between employees and management. It also helps create a more human-centered approach to Business Information Systems governance.

Overall, these practical implications show that the ethical problems of remote employee monitoring cannot be solved only by following the law. Sri Lankan organizations need a wider approach that includes clear policies, transparency, accountability, employee involvement, and respect for privacy. As remote work continues to grow in Sri Lanka, organizations that include ethical principles in their monitoring practices will be in a better position to protect employee trust, support well-being, and maintain productivity in a responsible way.

Overall Conclusion

This chapter has critically discussed the research findings in terms of the available literature, law, and ethics governing principles, and the Social Exchange Theory. The research showed that monitoring of employees has become normal and a norm in the remote working environment in Sri Lanka. Although the last two factors are sometimes neglected to consider, although much of the time the implementation of monitoring systems is performed to improve accountability and efficiency within an organization, the influences of monitoring systems go beyond measuring performance to include privacy, trust, and psychological well-being.

The results show that even though monitoring can offer structural control measures, it does not necessarily mean that it can be used to ensure enhanced productivity. Rather, the perceptions of fairness, transparency, and proportionality have a powerful impact on the way the employees will react. The privacy issue is also a big concern, especially with regard to the prominence of the personal and professional domain in the remote working environment. Further indications of moderate stress levels are that the sustained oversight could be cumulative in its psychological effect.

Theoretical perspective on the application of the Social Exchange theory proves that monitoring practices influence reciprocal relationships within organizations. When the monitoring is open and managed ethically, the employees will be more inclined to react with trust and dedication. Nonetheless, such over-surveillance or lack of proper communication can undermine relational balance. The professional ethical standards, especially those that focus on integrity, fairness and harm avoidance, which are incorporated to support the requirement of responsible system design and governance.

In general, remote work practices are sustainable in Sri Lanka, which requires the consideration of both the technological capability and ethical responsibility. Digital governance should be able to uphold the dignity of the employees but promote justifiable organizational goals.

Chapter 6

Future Recommendations

Introduction

In this chapter, all the recommendations will be offered based on Chapter 4 and 5 findings and discussions. The recommendations follow the research objectives directly and are aimed at informing the Sri Lankan organizations, Business Information Systems (BIS) designers, and policymakers to use ethically responsible and performance oriented remote monitoring systems.

The results showed that despite the prevalence of monitoring practices in Sri Lanka, the issues of privacy, trust, autonomy, and psychological well-being are still important. Thus, the solutions to this chapter will be to reconcile technology potential with quality ethics so that productivity goals may be realized without undermining the dignity of employees and the relationship trust.

Recommendations Aligned with Research Objectives

Recommendations Aligned with Objective 1

Objective 1: To investigate Sri Lankan remote workers' ethical concerns about employee privacy in monitoring systems.

The results indicated that there were serious privacy issues among the remote workers especially because of the reduction in personal and professional lines between home-based working setups. In turn, an organization with a transparency-based monitoring framework is its response. This calls upon the creation of well-written monitoring policies that clearly state the kind of data monitored, the purpose of processing the data, access control, and the storage times. Monitoring mechanisms should not keep employees in doubt. In the event of open clarification of privacy expectations, the perceptions of covert surveillance are reduced and moral legitimacy is augmented.

Moreover, companies ought to adopt stringent data minimization measures in their Business Information Systems. Monitoring tools should be fitted so that only the required information pertaining to work get recorded. Constant screen shots capturing, keystroke monitoring or webcam

surveillance are intrusive techniques that should not be used unless both required by law and reasonably so. Constricted data gathering minimizes the risk of ethics and reinforces the adherence to the principles of data protection. Also, a system that enables employees to analyze and view their own performance data should be implemented to strengthen the notion of fairness and transparency.

Recommendations Aligned with Objective 2

Objective 2: To evaluate how employee monitoring procedures affect workers' trust, motivation, and productivity.

Since the results of the Research revealed combined productivity results and average levels of trust, the task of organizational restructuring in the context of performance surveillance is to be reconsidered. Instead of being closely dependent on behavioral surveillance or even time-based surveillance, a shift towards outcome-based performance assessment is suggested. Measuring the deliverables, project milestones and quality indicators keeps employee autonomy intact and ensures accountability. These models facilitate intrinsic motivation which is very vital in remote working environments that are knowledge based.

Moreover, structured communication sessions must be implemented in an organization prior to and during implementation of monitoring systems. The employees should be aware of the purpose, extent, and usefulness of monitoring technologies. Opposite to the Social Exchange Theory, transparent explanation lowers misinterpretation and eliminates the feelings of managerial mistrust. The assessment of employee well-being needs to be institutionalized regularly as well to detect stress patterns associated with the intensity of the monitoring. When the stress indicators start rising but productivity does not improve, the monitoring strategies need to be varied accordingly.

Recommendations Aligned with Objective 3

Objective 3: To examine how employers and employees view remote work monitoring tools.

The perceived monitoring varies across stakeholders hence participatory mechanisms of governance are suggested. Companies ought to engage the employer and employees when developing and appraising monitoring policies. Organizations gain perceived fairness and legitimacy by including the employee input in the development of the policies. The engagement mitigates power imbalance and enhances the balance in relations in remote work settings.

In addition, there should be formal grievance and appeal systems. The monitoring-based evaluations should also have clear avenues through which employees can doubt, seek clarification, or object to such forms of evaluations. These mechanisms formulate the accountability and avoid misuse or misinterpretation of the monitoring information. This model will turn the system of monitoring into a regulated and ethically controlled method.

Recommendations Aligned with Objective 4

Objective 4: To determine the best practices and ethical frameworks that promote privacy protection and boost efficiency.

The results indicate that institutionalized ethical governance mechanisms and frameworks in the Business Information Systems are necessary. They ought to create internal digital ethics committees to monitor practices of surveillance, understand proportionality, and periodically audit compliance. Ethical governance should be an ongoing process not a decision that is made once.

Also, privacy-by-design should be embraced in the monitoring systems. Ethical protection should be put in place when the system is being developed and not retroactively. Functionality like role-based access control, automatic deletion of data, limited secondary processes of data, and inbuilt transparency notification must be incorporated at the system architecture level. This is to make sure that technological capabilities are bounded within ethical standards; that mission creep or over-surveillance does not happen.

Recommendations Aligned with Objective 5

Objective 5: To make suggestions for BIS design that maintain productivity and trust while guaranteeing ethical monitoring.

In achieving efficiency and trust, organizations can redesign BIS dashboards to emphasize the aggregated output-oriented performance measures instead of the detailed behavioral monitoring. Trust-based dashboards minimize the feeling of being under constant monitoring and, yet, offer managerial control. This design ethos backs accountability, yet not the autonomy.

In addition, ethical controls must be computerized in surveillance systems. Monitoring of intensity should raise alarms when it is more than the proportionally agreed limits, so that there is control over the monitoring within acceptable limits. Monitoring necessity should also be evaluated on a regular basis to identify whether or not technological supervision is still producing meaningful output. With organizations evolving in the practices of remote management, it is quite natural that intensive monitoring will be reduced, which will support sustainable, trust-based digital governance.

Strategic Policy Recommendations for Sri Lanka

In addition to the organizational-level responses, there should be more extended national and sector-level policy responses to be made on the ethical and sustainable use of employee monitoring systems in Sri Lanka. Since remote work is still growing in a variety of sectors, lack of a regulated framework would result in unequal and even intrusive habits. That is why, it is highly suggested to develop the sector-specific digital monitoring guidelines. The industries involved in IT, finance, education and government institutions have different degrees of data sensitivity and risk of operations. Individualized instructions in every industry would assist to harmonize productivity control together with context specific privacy demands.

On a national scale, more precise regulatory guidelines on ethical surveillance of employees during remote work should be presented. Although the general labor and data protection guidelines offer a basis, clear guidelines on digital monitoring within a home-based working environment would help to decrease the level of ambiguity in both employer and employee-related matters. There

would be clear regulatory standards that would outline the acceptable boundaries of monitoring, principles of proportionality, consent requirements, and accountability mechanisms. This transparency would increase the confidence in the digital employment practices, and decrease the possible legal conflicts.

Secondly, managed awareness campaigns ought to be provided to sensitize employers especially those in the small and medium scale business about responsible Business Information Systems governance. Monitoring technologies are used in many organizations, and their usage is mainly aimed at productivity improvement without a proper understanding of ethical issues. Responsible adoption practices could be encouraged by means of training programs and workshops of professionals and seminars in the industry with the focus on fairness, transparency, and minimizing harm.

Lastly, the long-term change entails the inclusion of digital ethics parts into university-level business, IT, and management courses. The ethical decision-making skills should be imparted before future managers, system developers, and policymakers can be introduced into the professional environment. Incorporating digital governance and surveillance ethics in academic courses will enable the production of a workforce that will be able to strike a balance between technological innovation and human-focused ethics. The proactive reform of the regulatory environment and further development of education can help Sri Lanka enforce ethical digital transformation and reduce long-term risks in relationships and organizations.

Recommendations for Future Research

Although the study is very useful as it offers much information on employee monitoring as practiced in remote work settings in Sri Lanka, there are various opportunities that can be explored through further academic research. To begin with, longitudinal studies are encouraged to investigate the dynamics of trust over the course of time when monitoring in conditions of sustained monitoring. Cross sectional studies only record the perception at a certain point in time but trust and motivation could evolve as the employees get used to technological supervision. Extensive studies would be used to gain further insight on relational sustainability in digitally monitored workplaces.

Second, comparative studies within certain industries like information technology, finance and education would provide more detailed information. The intensity, data sensitivity and work structure are monitored differently in various industries. Sector-based comparisons would enable the researcher to recognize best practices that would be applied according to the demands of the situation instead of consistent governance models.

In addition, qualitative research design such as in-depth interviews and focus group discussions are suggested to help reflect on the emotional and psychological experiences of monitored employees. Quantitative surveys can give quantifiable tendencies, and qualitative analysis can reveal hidden issues in the context of dignity, autonomy, stress, and perceived justice. The emotional aspects of this are vital towards comprehending the bigger picture of social implications of digital surveillance.

Possible variations in monitoring practices in the public and private sector should also be researched in future. Culture of organization, accountability systems and regulatory controls can affect the implementation and perception of monitoring systems. Policy formulation and governance recommendations would become more robust when analyzed using comparative institutional analysis.

Lastly, as the use of artificial intelligence continues to become more relevant in the context of productivity analytics, future research ought to explore the concept of AI-based monitoring systems in Sri Lankan companies. The use of algorithmic decision-making brings some new issues associated with the transparency, bias, explain ability, and accuracy of automated evaluation. The ethical effects of the use of AI-based surveillance will continue to gain relevance as technological advances continue to increase.

Future research can enhance ethical structures of governance through research depth, increased variety in methodology, and sectoral analysis and it can enhance policy growth that is evidence-based and strikes the necessary balance between efficiency and human dignity.

Chapter Summery

This chapter introduced logical, goal-oriented suggestions that were based on the empirical research and ethical considerations of the research. This competence by balancing the technological capability with privacy protection, protection of trust, and professional ethics allows Sri Lankan organizations to deploy employee monitoring systems which are effective in operations and do not lead towards any compromise in dignity, fairness, and equilibrium of relationships. Finally, sustainable remote work neither simply relies on the surveillance capacity, but the maturity of governance, transparency in practice and development of long-term organizational trust and integrity.

Executive Summary

This research investigates how remote work monitoring systems create privacy concerns and how those concerns relate to productivity among Sri Lankan remote workers. Using an interpretivist, exploratory-descriptive approach grounded in Social Exchange Theory, the study collected data through a Google Forms survey distributed via convenience sampling. A total of 60-70 respondents from job fields dominated by IT provided perceptions of monitoring practices, privacy, trust, stress, and productivity. Descriptive analysis in R shows monitoring is prevalent: roughly three quarters reported being monitored, and most experienced monitoring always, often, or sometimes. Screen/activity monitoring and time tracking were the most common tools; intrusive methods such as keystroke logging were less frequent, though a “not sure” group indicates limited transparency. Privacy concern was strong, with most respondents agreeing monitoring raises privacy issues. Trust in ethical data use leaned positive but was conditional, reflected by many neutral responses. Productivity impact was mixed and centered near neutrality, while stress perceptions leaned neutral-to-agree. Overall, monitoring was not widely viewed as improving work performance. The report recommends governed BIS: clear policies, informed consent, data minimization, limited retention, role-based access, employee participation, regular audits, and a shift from activity metrics to outcome-based evaluation aligned with Sri Lanka’s PDPA principles.

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Appendices

Questionnaires

The screenshot shows the first section of a Google Form. The title is "Ethical Concerns on Employee Privacy in Remote Work Monitoring Systems and Its Impact on Employee Productivity Among Remote Workers in Sri Lankan Context". Below the title is a description: "This survey examines productivity, privacy issues, and employee monitoring among Sri Lankan remote workers. Your answers are kept private and utilized exclusively for scholarly research." The first question is "1. Do you agree to take part in this survey voluntarily?" with radio button options for "Yes" and "No". A progress bar at the bottom indicates "After section 1 Continue to next section".

Final_Research_form ☆

Questions Responses Settings

Section 1 of 6

Ethical Concerns on Employee Privacy in Remote Work Monitoring Systems and Its Impact on Employee Productivity Among Remote Workers in Sri Lankan Context

This survey examines productivity, privacy issues, and employee monitoring among Sri Lankan remote workers. Your answers are kept private and utilized exclusively for scholarly research.

1. Do you agree to take part in this survey voluntarily? *

☐ Yes

☐ No

After section 1 Continue to next section

Section 2 of 6

Demographic Information

Description (optional)

2. What is your job field? *

☐ Information Technology (IT / Software)

☐ Business / Administration

☐ Education / Online Teaching

☐ Customer Support / BPO

☐ Freelancing / Digital Services

The screenshot shows the second section of the Google Form, titled "Demographic Information". It contains two questions: "2. What is your job field? *" and "3. In which province do you currently work from? *". The first question has radio button options for "Information Technology (IT / Software)", "Business / Administration", "Education / Online Teaching", "Customer Support / BPO", "Freelancing / Digital Services", and "Other". The second question has radio button options for "Western Province", "Central Province", "Southern Province", "Northern Province", "Eastern Province", "North Western Province", "North Central Province", "Uva Province", and "Saberagamuwa Province". A progress bar at the bottom indicates "4. How long have you been working remotely? *".

Final_Research_form ☆

Questions Responses Settings

Section 2 of 6

Demographic Information

Description (optional)

2. What is your job field? *

☐ Information Technology (IT / Software)

☐ Business / Administration

☐ Education / Online Teaching

☐ Customer Support / BPO

☐ Freelancing / Digital Services

☐ Other

3. In which province do you currently work from? *

☐ Western Province

☐ Central Province

☐ Southern Province

☐ Northern Province

☐ Eastern Province

☐ North Western Province

☐ North Central Province

☐ Uva Province

☐ Sabaragamuwa Province

4. How long have you been working remotely? *

Final_research_form

QuestionsResponsesSettings

Use Province

Sebangamawe Province

4. How long have you been working remotely? *

Less than 1 year

1 ~ 2 years

3 ~ 4 years

More than 4 years

After section 2 Continue to next section

Section 3 of 5

Employee Monitoring

Description (optional)

5. Are you monitored using any digital tools while working remotely? *

Yes

No

Not Sure

6. What type of monitoring is mainly used? *

Time tracking

Screen or activity monitoring

Webcam monitoring

Final_research_form

QuestionsResponsesSettings

5. Are you monitored using any digital tools while working remotely? *

Yes

No

Not Sure

6. What type of monitoring is mainly used? *

Time tracking

Screen or activity monitoring

Webcam monitoring

Keystroke or mouse tracking

Not Sure

7. How often are you monitored during working hours? *

Always

Often

Sometimes

Rarely

Never

After section 3 Continue to next section

Section 4 of 5

Privacy & Ethics

Description (optional)

Final_Research_form

Published

QuestionsResponsesSettings

Section 4 of 5

Privacy & Ethics

Description (optional)

8. I feel that employee monitoring affects my privacy? *

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

9. I trust my organization to use monitoring data ethically? *

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

After section 4: Continue to next section

Section 5 of 5

Productivity Impact

Description (optional)

10. Employee monitoring helps me stay productive? *

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

11. Employee monitoring increases my work stress? *

☐ Strongly agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly disagree

12. Overall, employee monitoring has a positive impact on my work performance? *

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

Final_Research_form

Published

QuestionsResponsesSettings

Section 5 of 5

Productivity Impact

Description (optional)

10. Employee monitoring helps me stay productive? *

☐ Strongly Agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly Disagree

11. Employee monitoring increases my work stress? *

☐ Strongly agree

☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

☐ Strongly disagree

12. Overall, employee monitoring has a positive impact on my work performance? *

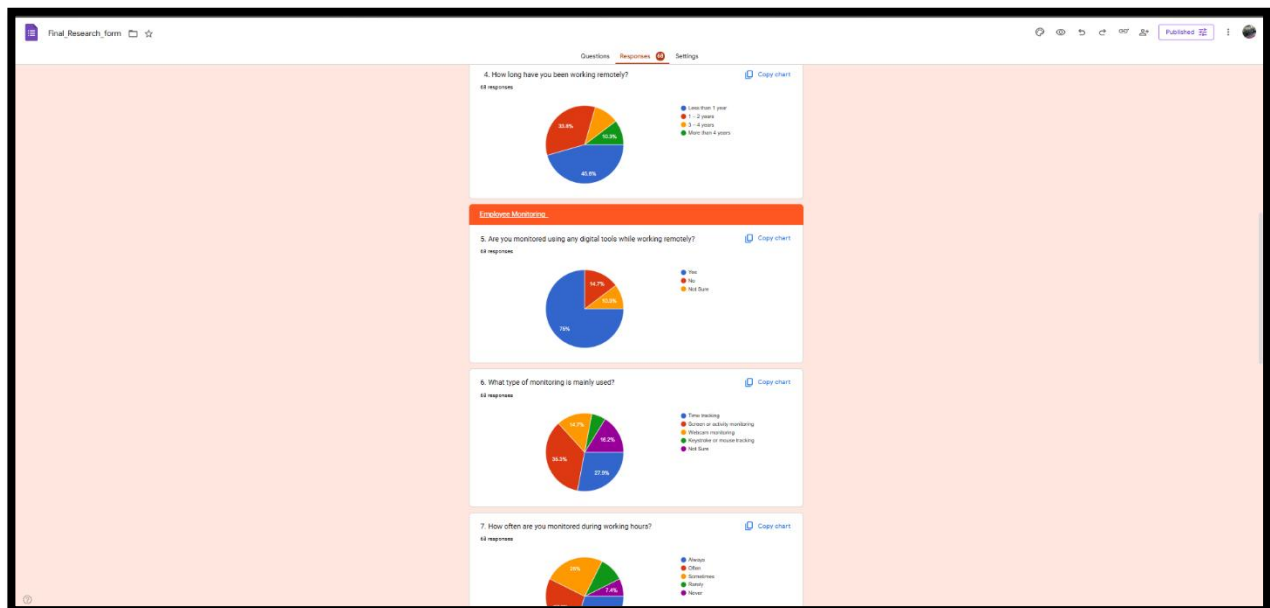
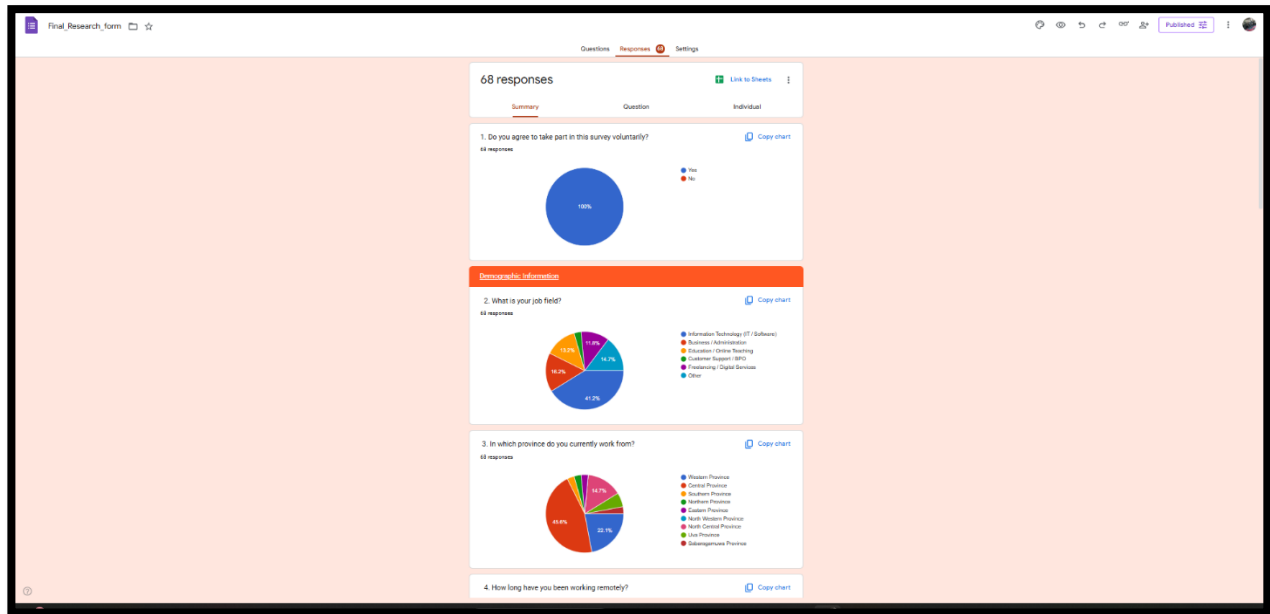
☐ Strongly Agree

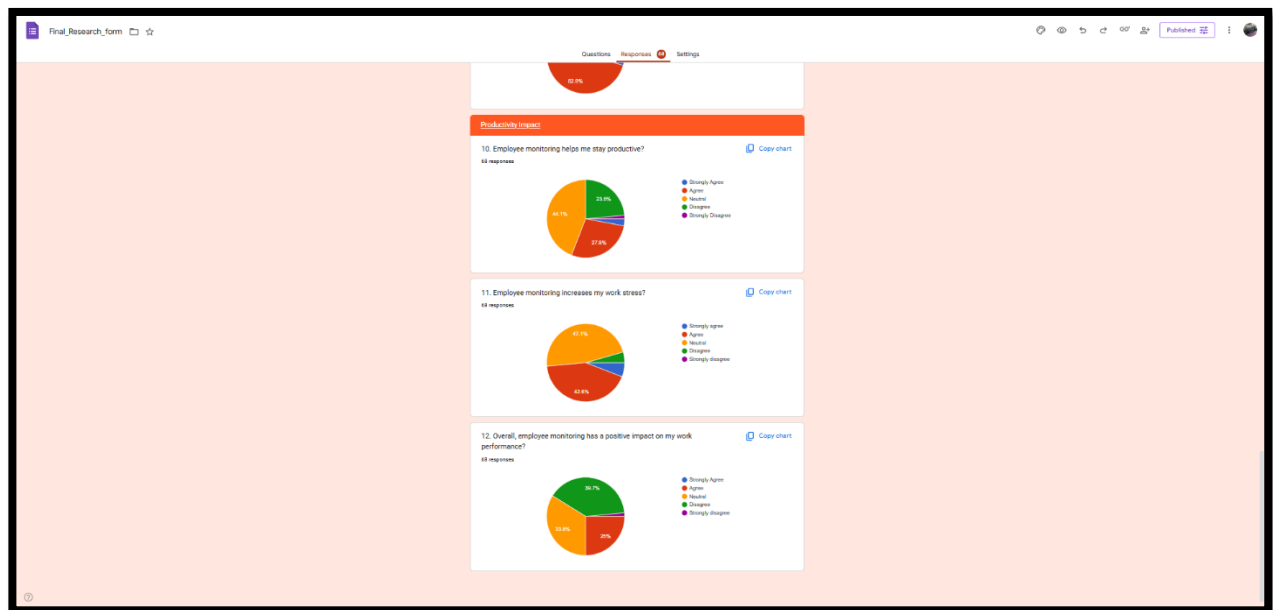
☐ Agree

☐ Neutral

☐ Disagree

Responses





R Studio Analyzing Part

```
1 # Load CSV
2 df <- read.csv("C:/Users/user/Desktop/thenuk/Final_Research_form_1.csv", header = TRUE)
3
4 # Check original column count
5 ncol(df)
6
7 # Remove first two columns
8 df <- df[, -c(1,2)]
9
10 # Check again
11 ncol(df)
12
13 # View updated dataset
14 view(df)
15
16 colnames(df) <- c(
17   "Job_Field",
18   "Province",
19   "Remote_Work_Experience",
20   "Monitoring_Used",
21   "Monitoring_Type",
22   "Monitoring_Frequency",
23   "Monitoring_Affects_Privacy",
24   "Trust_Monitoring_Data",
25   "Monitoring_Helps_Productivity",
26   "Monitoring_Increases_Stress",
27   "Positive_Impact"
28 )
29 view(df)
30
31 # create frequency table of Job Field
32 job_freq <- table(Final_Research_form$Job_Field)
33 # 5. Frequency table
34 job_freq <- table(Final_Research_form$Job_Field)
35 job_percent <- prop.table(job_freq) * 100
36
37 job_freq
38 job_percent
39
40
41 write.csv(Final_Research_form,
42   "Cleaned_Research_Data.csv",
43   row.names = FALSE)
44
```

```
44
45 # Pie chart of Job Field
46
47 pie(
48   job_freq, # frequency table
49   labels = paste(names(job_freq),
50     round(job_percent, 1), "%"),
51   main = "Distribution of Job Fields",
52   col = rainbow(length(job_freq))
53 )
54
55 barplot(job_freq,
56   main = "Job Field of Respondents",
57   xlab = "Job Field",
58   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
59   las = 2)
60
61 #province
62 province_freq <- table(df[,2])
63 province_percent <- prop.table(province_freq) * 100
64
65 province_freq
66 province_percent
67
68 barplot(province_freq,
69   main = "Province of Respondents",
70   xlab = "Province",
71   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
72   las = 2)
73
74 #pie chart
75 library(dplyr)
76 library(ggplot2)
77
78 # Province is in column 2 (q3)
79 prov_df <- df %>%
80   count(province = .[[2]]) %>%
81   mutate(
82     percent = n / sum(n) * 100,
83     label = paste0(round(percent, 1), "%")
84   )
85
86 # Create frequency table
87 province_freq <- table(df$Province)
88
```

```

84 )
85
86 # Create frequency table
87 province_freq <- table(df$Province)
88
89 # Convert to percentage
90 province_percent <- prop.table(province_freq) * 100
91
92
93 windows(width = 10, height = 8)
94
95 # pie chart
96 pie(
97   province_freq,
98   labels = paste0(names(province_freq), "\n",
99     round(province_percent, 1), "%"),
100   main = "Distribution of Province Frequency",
101   col = RColorBrewer::brewer.pal(length(province_freq), "Set3"),
102   cex = 1.1, # increase label size
103   font = 2, # bold text
104   clockwise = TRUE
105 )
106
107
108 # Pie chart
109 ggplot(prov_df, aes(x = "", y = n, fill = province)) +
110   geom_col(width = 1, color = "white", show.legend = TRUE) +
111   coord_polar(theta = "y") +
112   labs(
113     title = "Province of Respondents",
114     fill = "Province"
115   ) +
116   theme_void()
117
118 # Pie chart with % labels
119 ggplot(prov_df, aes(x = "", y = n, fill = province)) +
120   geom_col(width = 1, color = "white", show.legend = TRUE) +
121   coord_polar(theta = "y") +
122   geom_text(aes(label = label),
123     position = position_stack(vjust = 0.5),
124     size = 3) +
125

```

```

119 # Pie chart with % labels
120 ggplot(prov_df, aes(x = "", y = n, fill = province)) +
121   geom_col(width = 1, color = "white", show.legend = TRUE) +
122   coord_polar(theta = "y") +
123   geom_text(aes(label = label),
124     position = position_stack(vjust = 0.5),
125     size = 3) +
126   labs(
127     title = "Province of Respondents",
128     fill = "Province"
129   ) +
130   theme_void()
131
132 #remote work exp
133 experience_freq <- table(df[,3])
134 experience_percent <- prop.table(experience_freq) * 100
135
136 experience_freq
137 experience_percent
138
139
140
141 df$Remote_work_Experience <- factor(
142   df$Remote_work_Experience,
143   levels = c(
144     "Less than 1 year",
145     "1 - 2 years",
146     "3 - 4 years",
147     "More than 4 years"
148   )
149 )
150
151 experience_freq <- table(df$Remote_work_Experience)
152
153 barplot(
154   experience_freq,
155   main = "Remote Work Experience",
156   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
157   col = "#4E79A7",
158   las = 1
159 )
160 dev.off()
161
162 monitoring_used <- table(df[,4])
163 monitoring_percent <- prop.table(monitoring_used) * 100

```



```

165 monitoring_used
166 monitoring_percent
167
168 monitoring_used <- table(df$Monitoring_Used)
169
170 barplot(monitoring_used,
171         main = "Use of Employee Monitoring",
172         ylab = "Number of Respondents",
173         col = "#4E79A7",
174         las = 1)
175
176 monitoring_type <- table(df[,5])
177
178 monitoring_type
179
180 barplot(monitoring_type,
181         main = "Type of Monitoring",
182         xlab = "Monitoring Type",
183         ylab = "Number of Responses",
184         col = "#4E79A7",
185         las = 1)
186
187
188 monitoring_freq <- table(df[,6])
189
190 monitoring_freq
191
192 barplot(monitoring_freq,
193         main = "Monitoring Frequency",
194         xlab = "Frequency",
195         ylab = "Number of Respondents",
196         col = "#4E79A7",
197         las = 1)
198
199
200 likert_levels <- c("Strongly Disagree", "Disagree", "Neutral", "Agree", "Strongly Agree")
201
202 df$Privacy <- factor(df[,7], levels = likert_levels, ordered = TRUE)
203 df$Trust <- factor(df[,8], levels = likert_levels, ordered = TRUE)
204
205 df$Privacy_num <- as.numeric(df$Privacy)
206 df$Trust_num <- as.numeric(df$Trust)
207

```

```

208 table(df$Privacy)
209
210 barplot(
211   table(df$Privacy),
212   main = "Employee Monitoring and Privacy Concerns",
213   xlab = "Response",
214   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
215   col = "#4E79A7",
216   las = 1
217 )
218
219 library(Rcmdr)
220
221 boxplot(df$Privacy_num,
222         main = "Privacy Concern Distribution",
223         ylab = "Agreement Level")
224
225 # Frequency table of 'Trust' column
226 trust_table <- table(df$Trust)
227
228 # Bar plot
229 barplot(
230   trust_table,
231   main = "Trust in Ethical Use of Monitoring Data",
232   xlab = "Response",
233   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
234   col = "#4E79A7",
235   las = 1
236 )
237
238 boxplot(df$Trust_num,
239         main = "Trust Level Distribution",
240         ylab = "Agreement Level")
241
242 df$Productivity <- factor(df[,9], levels = likert_levels, ordered = TRUE)
243 df$Stress <- factor(df[,10], levels = likert_levels, ordered = TRUE)
244 df$Performance <- factor(df[,11], levels = likert_levels, ordered = TRUE)
245
246 df$Productivity_num <- as.numeric(df$Productivity)
247 df$Stress_num <- as.numeric(df$Stress)
248 df$Performance_num <- as.numeric(df$Performance)
249
250 table(df$Productivity)
251
252 barplot(
253   table(df$Productivity),

```

```

250 table(df$Productivity)
251
252 barplot(
253   table(df$Productivity),
254   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
255   main = "Monitoring and Productivity",
256   col = "#4E79A7"
257 )
258 boxplot(df$Productivity_num,
259   main = "Productivity Perception",
260   ylab = "Agreement Level")
261
262 table(df$Stress)
263
264 barplot(
265   table(df$Stress),
266   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
267   main = "Monitoring and stress",
268   col = "#4E79A7"
269 )
270 boxplot(df$Stress_num,
271   main = "Stress Perception",
272   ylab = "Agreement Level")
273
274 table(df$Performance)
275
276 barplot(
277   table(df$Performance),
278   ylab = "Number of Respondents",
279   main = "Overall Impact on work Performance",
280   col = "#4E79A7"
281 )
282 boxplot(df$Performance_num,
283   main = "Overall Performance Impact",
284   ylab = "Agreement Level")
285
286

```

Gannt Chart

